

**Let Go of the Past and
Reclaim Your Life
with Cognitive Behavioral
Therapy**



CBT For Beginners

**Author
CBT Specialist
Sara Adham**

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Introduction:

Dear Reader,

The term "Cognitive Behavioral Therapy" might initially seem complex, ambiguous, or even boring. It is a relatively modern term that entered the field of psychotherapy in the 1960s. Since then, it has rapidly evolved, proving its effectiveness in achieving the meaningful change that therapists aspire to bring to their patients' lives.

Before delving into the concepts of Cognitive Behavioral Therapy, I would like to take you on a personal journey that profoundly impacted my life. It is the story of my own experience with therapy and how I transformed from someone drowning in the darkness of depression and chronic anxiety into a person striving to help others overcome their psychological crises and regain their balance.

Moving to Sweden was neither a coincidence nor a trivial decision. It was the most significant choice I ever made to secure a safe future for my young children. This happened in September 1993, when I held the hands of my three children while carrying my fourth child in my womb, heading toward an uncertain future with no clear direction or guaranteed safety. It was not an adventure but an essential decision for survival.

Life in Sweden was the complete opposite of what I had known in Iraq, where war, death, and human cruelty were daily realities. I found myself in a completely different world: new faces, an unfamiliar language, strange customs and laws, and a cold yet mesmerizingly beautiful environment.

In the midst of my attempts to adapt, a day came that changed the course of my life forever. I experienced a severe panic attack, which I thought was a fatal heart attack that would leave me powerless and alone, facing an unknown fate for my children. But what I discovered was surprising: my heart was perfectly healthy, and my body bore no physical illnesses. The problem, as the doctor explained, was in my mind. He suggested I see a psychotherapist, even though I didn't believe in the value of such therapy at the time, considering it exclusive to the "weak" or the "privileged."

I entered the first session filled with doubt and apprehension. How could someone who had never lived my life understand the depths of my fears? But something shifted when the therapist, with blue eyes and blonde hair, asked me: "Sara, how do you feel sitting here in front of me right now?"

I mechanically replied, "I'm fine, perhaps I just need some sleep."

But she gently persisted: "What keeps you up at night and prevents you from sleeping?"

I couldn't answer. The words were stuck in my chest, trapped by vague emotions. Sensing my hesitation, she asked me to take a deep breath, assuring me that I was in a safe place free of judgment and criticism.

That moment was a turning point. I felt tears streaming uncontrollably down my face, tears I hadn't shed in years, as if racing to announce their long-repressed presence. I cried like never before, and instead of being met with criticism or pity, the therapist gently held my hand and said in a calm voice: "Crying is a blessing... Allow yourself to feel, for emotions don't need permission to be real."

I left that session with swollen eyes and a lighter heart, as if I had set down a heavy burden that had been obstructing my steps. It was then that I realized healing begins with acceptance, and emotions are not a sign of weakness but the truest reflection of our weary souls.

That blonde-haired woman, in just one session, became a safe haven for me. Through her, I learned that my thoughts create my emotions and that these thoughts, consciously or unconsciously, take root in my mind, hidden in dark places that need the light of understanding to dissipate.

I came to understand that healing requires readiness, openness, and commitment. It takes time, proportional to the depth of the wounds life has left in our souls.

Today, after years of studying and working in the field of psychotherapy, I have decided to share with you the basics of this wonderful therapy that saved me in the darkest moments of my life.

This book is your companion, a resource you can turn to whenever you seek a deeper understanding of yourself or wish to improve the quality of your life. I've endeavored to avoid linguistic complexities and present the concepts in a simple and practical manner, suitable for various levels.

If you are seeking healing, remember that commitment, openness, and acceptance are your essential keys. And if you aspire to become a psychotherapist, empathy, confidentiality, and neutrality are indispensable pillars.

Finally, I thank you from the depths of my heart for choosing this book to be a companion on your personal journey. It is a great honor for me to be part of your path toward a more conscious and peaceful life.

Do not hesitate to reach out to me if you have any comments or suggestions. This book is for you, me, and everyone who aspires to live with a tranquil heart and a mindful soul.

Important Note: All stories mentioned in this book are real; however, names and locations have been changed to preserve the privacy of those involved, with their full consent and in adherence to the professional ethics I deeply respect and uphold.

With sincere gratitude and appreciation,
Sara Adham

Chapter One:

Cognitive Behavioral Therapy: A Window to the Self

Understanding the human psyche is like trying to decode a complex cipher. Thoughts, emotions, and behaviors intertwine in a dynamic system that determines how we perceive the world and interact with it. Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT) offers a new window into understanding this system, giving us the tools to reshape it in ways that serve our happiness and well-being.

At its core, CBT focuses on the relationship between thoughts (what we think), emotions (how we feel), and behaviors (what we do). This triangular interaction is key to understanding why we behave in certain ways and how we can break the cycle of negative thinking and unhealthy behaviors.

How Does CBT Work?

CBT is based on a simple yet powerful premise: **"What we think influences how we feel, and how we feel affects what we do."**

For example:

- If you encounter a challenging situation and think, "I always fail," this thought might make you feel sad or frustrated. As a result, you might avoid trying to address the situation, leading to repeated failure.
- However, if you learn to reframe that thought into, "I might be struggling now, but this is an opportunity to learn," you might feel more hopeful and take a positive step toward improving the situation.

A Historical Glimpse: How CBT Was Born

The story of CBT began in the mid-20th century when American psychiatrist Aaron Beck observed that people with depression tended to think in distorted and negative ways. Instead of solely analyzing their emotions or childhood experiences, Beck proposed a practical approach that focused on changing their thought patterns.

Since then, CBT has evolved into one of the most effective therapeutic approaches, supported by thousands of scientific studies proving its ability to address a wide range of psychological issues.

Why Is CBT Effective?

CBT stands for a revolution in psychotherapy for several reasons:

1. **Evidence-Based:** Every technique used in CBT has been scientifically tested.
2. **Goal-Oriented and Short-Term:** Unlike some other approaches, CBT focuses on achieving tangible results within a relatively short period.
3. **Practical and Interactive:** It equips patients with tools they can use independently to improve their lives.
4. **Widely Applicable:** It is used to treat anxiety, depression, eating disorders, professional performance, and many other psychological and personality challenges.

The Triangular Interaction: Thoughts, Emotions, and Behaviors

To understand CBT, imagine an equilateral triangle. At each corner lies one of the following elements:

1. **Thoughts:** "What am I telling myself?"
2. **Emotions:** "How do I feel about this?"
3. **Behaviors:** "What do I do as a result?"

Each corner influences the others. If you change one corner, it affects the other two.

Example: Reham and the New Job

Reham, a new employee, began feeling extremely anxious after making a minor mistake at work. Her immediate thoughts were, "This means I will never succeed," and, "Others will think I'm incompetent." These thoughts led to feelings of fear and frustration, prompting her to avoid asking for help to prevent others from discovering her "incompetence," even though her thoughts had no supporting evidence.

This avoidance and pretense created discomfort and fear of the workplace, pushing Reham to blame others for mistakes to gain temporary confidence rather than focus on her growth.

Reham turned to CBT to rid herself of the negative emotions that were starting to dominate her professional life. She decided to implement simple techniques by asking herself basic questions whenever she felt afraid or anxious:

- "Do I have any evidence that I will never succeed?"

- "Can I learn from this mistake?"
- "Have others really made me feel incompetent?"

Reham used the technique of challenging fear-induced thoughts by countering them with logical and practical responses. Despite her anxiety and hesitation, she took a brave step and asked a colleague for help. A lingering thought gripped her: "What if my colleague uses this request to make me feel even less competent at my job?"

But she didn't give in to these fears and quickly asked herself: "Do I have any real evidence of this?"

Her answer led her to overcome her anxiety and face the situation. When she asked her colleague for help, she was surprised! He responded warmly, expressed his willingness to support her, and even extended a sincere invitation to approach him with any future difficulties or questions.

Reham left his office with a bright smile on her face and a sense of relief and confidence. She returned to her desk full of positive energy, ready to tackle her tasks with renewed enthusiasm. She realized that confronting fears with logic could open doors she never expected.

What's Next?

In the coming chapters, we will delve deeper into how to identify negative thoughts, challenge them, and replace them with healthier alternatives. You will discover tools and techniques that will help you gain a deeper understanding of yourself, break free from cycles of negative thinking, and lead a more balanced and fulfilling life.

Chapter Two:

Understanding Negative Thoughts

The Power of the Past and Its Impact

Every experience we go through carries within it a lesson or a feeling that takes root deep inside us, contributing to shaping our outlook on life and our way of dealing with the future. Some experiences leave a positive imprint, pushing us forward, granting us confidence, and nourishing our spirit with optimism.

On the other hand, there are negative experiences that form obstacles hindering our psychological growth. Their impact extends deeper than positive experiences because they penetrate the soul and touch our deepest fears and doubts. However, despite their harshness, these experiences play a significant role in developing our awareness and understanding of ourselves if we handle them correctly.

Negative experiences are not the end of the road; rather, they are the beginning of new understanding, a test of our strength, and an opportunity to rise stronger than before.

Example

Ahmed, a diligent university student, decided one day to try something new and join a debating activity. During his participation, Ahmed forgot some important points and received direct criticism from his professor. This incident affected him deeply, leading him to believe that he is "incapable of public speaking" and that "his memory will fail him again, causing him embarrassment and further criticism."

Later, when he was given a second chance to take part in a debate, the idea of failure completely dominated him. Succumbing to fear, he politely declined the opportunity, allowing another colleague to take his place. In Ahmed's mind, his professor's words seemed like absolute truth and a certain prediction of what would happen in his future attempts.

But the reality is that Ahmed did not give himself a second chance to try; instead, he based his decision on feelings of fear rather than logical thinking. He generalized a single experience to all similar situations he might face, ignoring that each new situation brings different people and new opportunities.

What distinguishes Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT) is its ability to help individuals differentiate between a specific experience and absolute generalization. Through this type of therapy, a person can learn effective techniques to confront negative thoughts and replace them with constructive new ones.

Therapy provides the opportunity to return to the foundational thought that has become an obstacle on the path of progress and work on modifying it in a way that redirects thinking toward a more positive path. This new approach not only helps overcome obstacles but also opens doors to experiences that grant the individual a chance for personal and professional growth.

Core Beliefs: The Hidden Rules That Govern Our Lives

Core beliefs are what we believe about ourselves. They are like a religion or an unquestionable belief that has taken root since early childhood, occupying a strategic place in the subconscious mind, accessible only through significant challenge and effort. These are deep thoughts that influence how we view ourselves and the world around us. Often, these beliefs are not consciously recognized due to their presence in the subconscious, but they play a major role in shaping our decisions and reactions.

In psychology, a belief is defined as an idea or set of ideas that an individual holds to be true, whether based on logical evidence or resulting from personal experiences or social and cultural influences. Beliefs greatly affect a person's thinking, behavior, and emotions and play a pivotal role in shaping viewpoints, habits, and ways of dealing with life. The danger of negative beliefs lies in their formation as convictions rather than hypotheses. Conviction is one of the most challenging things for a person to change, especially when it relates to self-worth.

Example

Suad is a woman who walks with apparent confidence, carrying within her a pure kindness and boundless generosity. She is a model of success that shines in the eyes of others, but behind this brilliance hides a heart burdened with a deep-seated feeling that she does not deserve the love she so generously gives. Her life resembles a constant journey to please everyone, meeting their needs and sacrificing herself while always leaving herself as the last priority.

This deep wound in Suad's soul was not born by chance but grew from a harsh childhood. At the age of five, she faced her first betrayal when her mother left her without farewell. Suad was left to live with a father constantly absent due to his travels and a grandmother whose harsh voice reminded her of her mother's absence, telling her that being abandoned was not difficult.

Suad grew up carrying an inner certainty that she was a burden to others and that love and attention were not her rights but gifts conditioned on exerting effort beyond her capacity. This painful feeling became more entrenched with every comparison she faced and every

phrase like: "Why aren't you smart like your cousin?" or "What's wrong with you?" These words were not mere criticisms but repeated messages that Suad was not enough as she was.

Over time, these beliefs extended into her marital and professional life. She succeeded in building an honorable professional career but continued to bear full responsibility both at work and at home. Her husband, who was supposed to be a partner, withdrew from his parental role while she carried the entire burden. She was repeating the same pattern she had lived in her childhood, striving to avoid criticism and create a perfect image, fearing that fate would repeat itself and others would abandon her as her mother did.

As days passed, this pressure weighed heavily on her. Episodes of depression and panic appeared, and sudden anger overwhelmed her without understanding its source. She felt as if she were wrestling with the ghosts of her past, trapped in a vicious cycle of exhausting giving and constant fear, while her silent question echoed: "When will I deserve love... without conditions?"

Ultimately, Suad sought the help of a psychotherapist who uses CBT techniques. Shame and feelings of disgrace enveloped Suad's thoughts, and she thought the therapist would belittle her ideas because they were worthless. However, she was surprised at how the therapist directly addressed the wound and began a therapeutic journey that restructured Suad's thoughts and beliefs about herself.

CBT allowed Suad to reconsider her achievements and change her behaviors toward herself first and then others. When Suad's belief about herself changed, others' behaviors toward her changed accordingly. We will later discuss some important techniques that can be used to challenge the negative thoughts and beliefs we hold about ourselves and how to change them.

The Surrounding Environment: The Major Player in Shaping Our Thoughts

The surrounding environment is not just a backdrop to our lives; it is a primary factor in shaping our identity and thoughts. Family, friends, and even society play significant roles in instilling ideas and beliefs that affect us directly and indirectly.

Another Example

Youssef, an ambitious young man in his late twenties, grew up in a family that had a strict definition of success: a prestigious job with a steady income in one of the traditional fields like medicine or engineering. Since his childhood, he heard phrases like: "Real success is a job that guarantees you a stable life." Despite his respect for his family's values, Youssef's heartbeat with something entirely different: art.

When Youssef decided to pursue art, it was a brave but challenging step. He began working as a designer and painter, creating works and expressing himself through his paintings. Over time, he found himself facing great psychological pressure whenever he gathered with his family. The predominant discussion in those gatherings revolved around the unconventional profession Youssef had chosen, accompanied by looks filled with disappointment and deep doubt about his ability to choose. Even when criticism came subtly, the strong feeling Youssef carried was a sense of loneliness in his decision due to the lack of necessary support.

Youssef began to doubt his choices. Was his decision wrong? Does success truly mean only a job that brings a steady income? These thoughts infiltrated him and affected his confidence and ability to create. He started avoiding discussions with his family, feeling caught between his passion and meeting their expectations.

Amid this struggle, Youssef decided to seek help. He turned to CBT, where he began to discover new dimensions of his outlook on life. During the sessions, Youssef talked about his experience and his feeling of failure simply because he chose a different path. The therapist began helping him dismantle these thoughts one by one.

"What does success mean to you?" This was one of the pivotal questions posed to him. Gradually, Youssef realized that the definition of success is not absolute and that it can be personal, aligning with his values and goals. For him, success meant living his passion and leaving his mark on the world through his art.

Youssef learned to question the negative thoughts that dominated him. When attacked by a thought like: "I am not as successful as I should be," he began to ask himself: "What evidence do I have for that?" He then remembered his art exhibitions that were well-received, clients who praised his designs, and job opportunities that came from entities appreciating his creativity.

Through therapy, Youssef also learned how to communicate effectively with his family. He no longer felt the need to defend his choices but began to speak confidently and calmly about his vision for life, emphasizing his respect for his family's values. He clarified to them that his path was different but no less important or successful.

Over time, Youssef began to feel liberated from the pressure of comparison and others' expectations. His passion for art returned, and his creativity and productivity increased. His life became more balanced and happier, realizing that his true success lies in walking the path he chooses, not what is imposed upon him.

Types of Cognitive Distortions: The Distorted Lens Through Which We See the World

Cognitive distortions are mistaken patterns of thinking that lead to a distorted understanding of reality. These distortions are not part of the truth but the way we process information inaccurately. The danger of cognitive distortions is that they appear as facts while not belonging to the present reality. Some of these distortions include:

1- Catastrophic Thinking: Constantly expecting the worst.

When a person undergoes a painful experience, such as a divorce, the experience sometimes becomes like a distorted mirror reflecting an unrealistic image of the world. Under the influence of psychological pain, the individual may generalize that experience to everyone resembling the person who caused them harm. Suddenly, phrases like "All men are cheaters" or "All women are ungrateful" become convictions. These thoughts are not mere passing words but turn into a dark lens through which the individual views human relationships. Over time, they begin to withdraw from the world, preferring isolation over risking a new experience that might reopen old wounds.

This distortion in thinking is not limited to relationships but extends to other areas of life. Imagine someone applying for a job they consider their dream, tying all their happiness to the outcome. At that moment, acceptance or rejection becomes the decisive criterion for everything. They tell themselves: "If I don't get this job, my life will completely collapse."

In this way, the person sees their life from only one angle, a narrow lens that blinds them to all other possibilities and opportunities that might be awaiting them. This type of thinking weakens the spirit and confines it within a prison of absolute judgments and fear of the unknown, while life is full of colors and angles that can be discovered if one allows one to broaden their horizons and see things from a different perspective.

2- Overgeneralization: Drawing a broad conclusion based on a single experience.

This type of generalization not only affects how one views others but also extends to how individuals evaluate themselves and their capabilities. When a person generalizes a single failure to become a model for all future attempts, they enter a closed circle of frustration and stagnation. The belief becomes: "If I failed at first, it means I will always fail." With this assumption, they stop growing and developing, convinced that their abilities, or even their luck, will remain the same and that nothing will change what they consider their "destiny in life."

This mindset is evident in experiences requiring achievement in professional or practical situations. For example, when performing a task that ends with unsatisfactory results, the person instills in their mind a preconceived belief that this initial experience is evidence of perpetual failure. Worse still, they may enter the experience with a pre-existing intention to prove their belief in failure, as if the negative outcome were predetermined.

But it doesn't stop there. Often, this belief becomes a means to avoid future attempts. The fear of facing failure makes the individual prefer to delegate responsibilities to others, trapping themselves in a weak and negative corner. They tell themselves: "Why should I try? If I failed before, it means I will never succeed." And when what they fear happens, they confirm to themselves: "I was right; this is my fate."

In this way, the person deprives themselves of the opportunity to discover their true potential or learn from their mistakes. The truth is that life is not governed by a single attempt, nor defined by one experience. Every failure is a lesson, and every attempt is an opportunity to grow. Generalization, in this case, is nothing but an imaginary constraint the individual places upon themselves, preventing them from seeing the possibilities that might await if they abandon their fear and open new doors to try again.

3. Mind Reading: Assuming You Know What, Others Are Thinking Without Evidence

This cognitive distortion reflects how pessimism can dominate an individual's outlook on life and relationships, pushing them to interpret situations negatively without any concrete evidence to support their assumptions. Let's revisit Suad's story, where she often relied on her assumptions about others' intentions, ignoring real-world evidence. She would tell herself things like, "I'm certain that the praise I received is just an attempt to exploit me later," or, "My manager's compliment wasn't genuine; it was just pity or a fleeting courtesy."

This type of thinking isn't limited to professional relationships but manifests prominently in emotional and social interactions. A common example is interpreting a delay in responding to a message or call as a personal insult or a sign of disinterest in the relationship. In such situations, the person feels anxious and demands a quick response—not to resolve the issue but to ease the anxiety caused by the negative thought.

However, this insistence on an immediate reply often carries a form of control aimed at silencing the negative thought temporarily. It's a desperate attempt to achieve a sense of security, though it is often based on unrealistic and unjustified assumptions. In reality, such behaviors not only place an emotional burden on the relationship but also impose an unfair obligation on the other party.

Examples of thoughts in such situations include:

- "My colleague hasn't replied to my message, so they must dislike me."
- "My girlfriend hasn't responded to my messages, which means she doesn't care about me. I'm sure she read it and deliberately turned off her phone."

These thoughts reflect an unwarranted sense of entitlement, where others are expected to always be available and considerate of personal expectations. The truth, however, is that

this kind of control doesn't solve the problem but complicates relationships further, leading to greater emotional isolation.

To overcome this mindset, individuals need to recognize that temporary absence or a delayed response may have natural reasons unrelated to their self-worth or the significance of the relationship. Building trust begins with letting go of preconceived negative interpretations.

4. Personalization: Taking Full Responsibility for Events Beyond Your Control

This type of thinking dominates some individuals, causing them to bear the entire burden of responsibility in any relationship, as if they are the sole party to blame for any issues. This often occurs in relationships marked by emotional manipulation, where blame and neglect are prevalent, leaving the affected party surviving on mere scraps of affection while convinced that every problem is their fault.

In this dynamic, the person becomes an easy target for criticism, believing they deserve it. A clear example of this is growing up in a family environment marked by favoritism among siblings, where one child is chosen as the scapegoat for all the family's issues. This child grows up internalizing thoughts such as: "The problems between my parents are because of me," or "My husband's neglect is due to my shortcomings."

This thinking pattern leads to a loss of balanced perspective in relationships. The individual fails to see that healthy relationships are built on shared responsibilities, and that effective communication is a mutual duty.

CBT focuses on dismantling this psychological knot, helping individuals recognize that they are not the sole obstacle in relationships. Therapy begins by redefining the relationship from a more balanced perspective, teaching the individual that healthy relationships rely on mutual understanding and shared responsibilities—not one party carrying everything while the other absorbs themselves of accountability.

Therapeutic sessions encourage the person to question these thoughts, asking themselves:

- "Is there concrete evidence that I am always at fault?"
- "Could there be external factors or actions by the other party contributing to the issue?"

By asking these questions, the individual begins to view situations more comprehensively, helping alleviate feelings of guilt and reduce the burden they place on themselves.

Therapy also aims to build self-confidence by helping individuals recognize that others' opinions of them do not necessarily reflect reality. They learn that having problems in a

relationship does not equate to personal failure but may stem from shared factors requiring cooperation or a reassessment of the relationship's health for both parties.

Over time, individuals come to understand that healthy relationships rely on effective communication and balance, and they are not obligated to carry the entire burden. They might say to themselves:

- “My parents’ problems are the result of their own choices, not my responsibility.”
- “My husband’s neglect may be tied to personal issues unrelated to what I perceive as my shortcomings.”

With this new understanding, individuals free themselves from excessive guilt, enabling them to build relationships based on mutual respect and understanding rather than constant blame and emotional pressure.

How Negative Thoughts Affect Our Lives

Negative thoughts are not merely fleeting words in our minds; they are a hidden force with wide-ranging effects on our emotions, behaviors, and even physical health. If left unchecked, these thoughts can trigger a cascading cycle of psychological and physical decline.

1. Impact on Emotions

Negative thoughts fuel sadness, anxiety, and frustration. They charge us with negative energy that impacts both the mind and body. This negative energy is not a temporary feeling but a draining state that depletes psychological and physical resources, impairing clear thinking and effective action. Over time, these emotions become a heavy burden, preventing individuals from enjoying a healthy and balanced life.

2. Impact on Behaviors

When negative thoughts dominate a person's mind, they lead to destructive behaviors like avoidance, withdrawal, or procrastination. In an attempt to escape what feels unsafe, the individual clings to what is familiar and secure, though it often reinforces their sense of helplessness. This behavioral pattern diminishes their ability to handle life's challenges effectively, opening the door to psychological disorders like depression, generalized anxiety, paranoia, borderline personality disorder, and avoidant personality disorder. Avoidance does not protect against pain; it isolates individuals in a closed loop of fear and helplessness.

3. Impact on Physical Health

The effects of negative thoughts extend to the body, causing internal exhaustion that disrupts basic bodily functions. These thoughts lead to poor sleep quality, unhealthy eating habits, and reduced physical activity, further deteriorating physical health. Conditions partially attributed to these thoughts include fibromyalgia, chronic fatigue syndrome, and persistent headaches. Negative thoughts worsen internal stress, damaging vital systems like digestion, the heart, and muscles. This stress can escalate into severe health crises such as high blood pressure, digestive disorders, and irregular heartbeats.

Conclusion

Negative thoughts are not just a mental state; they are a force that affects the entire spectrum of life—from the inside out. If left unaddressed, they sow seeds of anxiety and despair, weaken the body and mind, and restrict a person's ability to move forward in life with confidence. Confronting them requires deep awareness of their impact and an ongoing effort to transform them into a positive force that restores balance to the mind and body.

Practical Steps to Deal with Negative Thoughts

1. Identifying the Thought

The first step in dealing with negative thoughts is to identify them. This process is the foundation for change because a negative thought is like a virus—it cannot be treated until its type is identified.

Types of Negative Thoughts

Some negative thoughts are clear and explicit, making them easier to identify and manage. However, the real challenge lies in dealing with **automatic negative thoughts**—those subtle, sneaky thoughts that invade the mind without warning. These thoughts are hypersensitive to any trigger, no matter how small: a certain smell, a familiar place, or even a passing image. They act as an invisible window that suddenly opens, whispering harsh words into the mind before retreating, leaving behind sadness, fear, or anxiety.

Steps to Identify Negative Thoughts:

1. Tracking the Emotional Trail:

To confront these thoughts, start by tracing their emotional impact. Ask yourself:

- “What is causing me to feel this way?”
Often, the initial response is:
- “I don’t know.”

This is a common occurrence, especially when someone experiences a crisis or event that leaves lingering negative emotions even after the event has passed.

2. **Understanding the Connection Between Emotions and Thoughts:**

Remember, every negative emotion starts with a thought. Having the courage to face these thoughts, even when they are painful, is key.

3. **The Essential Question:**

When experiencing a negative emotion, pause and ask:

- “What am I feeling right now? Why?”

These questions activate the brain, encouraging it to think critically and engage with thought rather than following it passively.

4. **Training and Patience:**

Consistently asking these questions trains the brain to recognize negative thoughts. Over time, identifying these thoughts becomes easier, initiating the journey toward regaining control over the mind and body.

2. **Writing Down the Thought**

Now, it’s time to grab a notebook and pen. Writing isn’t just an ordinary step; it’s your gateway to exploring the depths of your mind and uncovering hidden truths, emotions, and thoughts. This process helps connect your inner world with external realities.

Why Writing Matters:

As humans, we often act based on the emotions triggered by thoughts without pausing to question:

- “What’s the real cause of what I’m feeling?”

By writing, you give yourself the opportunity to organize your emotions and thoughts and gain clarity.

The Power of Writing:

1. **Emotional Release:** Writing helps you release all the pent-up emotions inside you, as though you are opening a window to let out the inner storm.

2. **Organizing Thoughts:** When you write down what you feel and think, everything becomes tangible and visible, creating clarity.
3. **Slowing Down the Chaos:** Handwriting naturally slows your mind, allowing thoughts to flow at the pace of your pen.

How to Begin:

- Reflect on the last situation that overwhelmed you emotionally.
- Write down your thoughts and emotions as they occurred during the event.
- As you write, you may feel like watching a slow-motion replay of your experience, revealing details you might have missed in that moment.

3. Challenging the Thought

Now comes the critical step: confronting the negative thought that has been influencing your emotions and actions.

Steps to Challenge the Thought:

1. Ask Bold Questions:

- “Where did you come from?”
- “Why are you here?”
- “Why have I believed you all this time?”
- “Who planted you in my mind, and how can I let you go?”

2. Reassess the Validity of the Thought:

A negative thought is like an intruder in your mind, claiming to know your truth. Confront it calmly to determine whether it’s accurate or merely an illusion.

For example:

- If you think, “I’m bound to fail this exam,” challenge this thought:
- “Why do I believe failure is inevitable?”

3. Visualize the Thought:

Imagine the thought as a physical entity. Look at it objectively, like a detective examining a suspect. Begin your interrogation:

- “Why do you think I will fail?”
- “What evidence do you have to support this?”
- “Why should I trust you when you’re based on past experiences that no longer define my present?”

Ask Key Questions to Counter the Thought:

1. **What evidence supports or contradicts this thought?**
2. **Can I view the situation from a different perspective?**

Take your time with these questions. Approach them as though you are solving a complex puzzle, allowing yourself the space to explore and uncover the truth.

Facing Negative Thoughts as an Internal Battle

A negative thought is a part of you, yet it’s a part that has grown accustomed to controlling and weakening you. Now, with your awareness and determination, you are in a position of power. Imagine this confrontation as an internal battle. You are the commander, and the thought is an intruder with no rightful place in your life. Every question you ask it is a weapon that weakens its grip on you.

For Example:

- When the thought tells you, "You will fail."
- Respond: "What proof do you have? What about my past successes? How dare you base your judgment on past experiences that no longer define my reality?"

Take Your Time:

This isn’t a battle that ends in a moment. Be patient and deliberate. The goal is not just to refute the thought but to train your mind not to surrender to it easily in the future.

4. Reframing the Thought: Building a New Perspective

The confrontation is complete. That hidden thought that roamed freely within you, controlling you without your notice, is now exposed. You’ve unmasked it, and there it stands—painful, harsh, and manipulative. It will try to convince you that it’s part of your truth because it doesn’t want to lose its privileged place in your mind. It will fight to dominate you, as has done many times before.

Stripping the Thought of Its Power:

But things are no longer the same. This thought is no longer hidden, which in itself weakens its strength. Just as a thief loses their ability to steal when the lights are turned on and their face is revealed, a negative thought loses its control when you see it clearly and confront it bravely.

Fighting the Old Thought:

Your mind is your most valuable asset, and you will do anything to protect it. To achieve this, you must unmask the negative thought, confirm its truth, and strip it of its power. But confronting the old thought isn't enough; you must replace it with a new, stronger thought, even if it feels weak initially. This new thought needs your nurturing and support to grow into your new reality.

How to Reframe a Thought?

1. Hold on to the New Thought:

Let both the old and new thoughts witness your determination. For instance, when you fear failing an exam, don't stop at the fear. Let the new thought become your inner voice:

- "I will take the exam, even if I'm scared. I might not succeed on the first try, but I'll learn and try again."

2. View the Situation from a Different Angle:

Ask yourself:

- "Is this exam truly that important? Can I study in a different way that helps me understand better?"
- "Failure isn't the end of the road but an opportunity to rethink and explore paths I might not have considered before."

Through this process, the new thought becomes more than just reassurance—it becomes a starting point for changing how you perceive things. What once seemed like closed doors now slowly opens, no longer barriers trapping you. You now hold the reins.

Practical Examples:

Example 1: A Friend Doesn't Respond to a Message

- Instead of thinking:

- “My friend didn’t reply to my message yesterday because they don’t care about me.”
- Reframe it:
 - “Maybe my friend is busy, or their phone is out of service. I’ll wait for a clear explanation before jumping to conclusions.”

Example 2: Nada, the Teacher

- **Original Thought:**
 - “I’m a failure, and I’ll never be a good teacher.”
- **Challenge the Thought:**
 - “Is there evidence that I’m a failure? Does the feedback mean I’m bad at my job?”
- **Reframe It:**
 - “The feedback is an opportunity to improve my skills, not a final judgment of my abilities.”

A Message for You:

Each time you encounter a new negative thought, remember that you have the power to challenge and reframe it. Don’t rush the results. Like a child who needs time to grow and strengthen, your new thoughts need patience and continuous nurturing to become strong enough to replace the old ones and transform your reality.

Every step you take in confronting your negative thoughts brings you closer to building a clearer, more aware mind. You are now on a journey worth undertaking toward your true, free, and confident self.

What’s Next?

Now that you understand the roots and impact of negative thoughts, it’s time to move on to practical tools offered by Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT). In the next chapter, we will explore how to use a **thought record** and **cognitive restructuring** to turn these thoughts into a positive force. Stay tuned!

Chapter Three

Core Techniques in Cognitive Behavioral Therapy: A Journey from Fear to Strength

A man in his late thirties walked into my clinic, his demeanor a mix of resilience and vulnerability. He was married and the father of a three-year-old daughter, yet his eyes held a hesitant look as if silently asking, "Can you really help me?" He sat down, his burden seemingly heavier than his physical presence, and said in a low yet sharp voice: "I'm not sure if therapy will help me, but I've run out of options."

The Beginning of the Journey: A Man Afraid of Fear

For years, he had been suffering from panic attacks that struck without warning. He described them as nightmares haunting his soul:

"I feel like I'm suffocating... like my heart will stop at any moment."

These episodes had driven him to the hospital numerous times, each time believing he was having a heart attack. Yet, the doctors always reassured him that his heart was perfectly healthy.

He said, "How can fear cause this much pain? A man isn't supposed to be afraid. A man is supposed to be strong."

These words weren't just passing remarks—they reflected deep-seated beliefs shaped by his upbringing. Growing up in a household where his father constantly repeated, "Don't cry. Men don't break," these messages became the lens through which he viewed himself and the world.

As the panic attacks intensified, escaping the truth was no longer possible. He admitted, "I need help, but I don't want anyone to know. I don't want people to think I'm weak."

CBT Techniques Used in Therapy

Step 1: Daily Journaling to Track Thoughts and Feelings

The journey began with difficulty. When I suggested he keep a journal of his thoughts and feelings, he replied with frustration,

"What's the point? Writing won't stop the fear."

I smiled and said,

"Writing isn't the cure itself, but it's the beginning. It's a way to see what's happening inside you instead of letting fear control you in the dark. The thoughts that scare us become less threatening when we confront them."

We started the first page together. I asked him to record:

1. **Situation:** What happened?
2. **Thought:** What were you thinking during the situation?
3. **Emotion:** How did you feel? Rate the intensity from 0 to 10.
4. **Behavior:** What did you do in response to those feelings?

Example from His Journal:

One day, he wrote about a work-related incident:

- **Situation:** A meeting with his manager to present a project idea.
- **Thought:** "I'll definitely forget important points, and the manager will see I'm nervous. He'll lose interest and think the idea is worthless."
- **Emotion:** Severe anxiety, 8/10.
- **Behavior:** He postponed the meeting and stayed home instead of facing the manager.

When he later reviewed his notes, he said,

"I didn't realize I was thinking this way. It feels like I live in my head more than I live in reality."

Step 2: Cognitive Restructuring

After identifying his negative thoughts through journaling, one core belief emerged: "I'm weak because I'm afraid."

Calmly and reassuringly, I asked him,

"Can you provide me with solid evidence that you're weak?"

He hesitated before replying,

"Fear makes me run away. I feel like I've lost control of my life."

I smiled and responded,

"But have you ever faced something difficult and succeeded?"

After a moment of reflection, he said,

"I graduated from college despite all the challenges. I have a stable job, and I love my family. But... the fear remains."

I explained to him that fear isn't an enemy, nor is it a sign of weakness.

"Fear is a completely natural emotion. It's not a flaw but a human reaction designed to protect us. Strength isn't about the absence of fear; it's about facing it."

Together, we replaced the distorted belief linking fear to weakness with a more balanced and human perspective:

- "Fear is a natural feeling, not a sign of weakness but a protective tool. Harmful fear can be overcome by confronting and challenging it rather than avoiding it."

This shift in perspective marked a turning point. He began to see fear as part of the human experience and as a signal for growth rather than a mark of weakness.

Step 3: Gradual Exposure Technique

Avoidance had been his preferred way of dealing with fear—avoiding public speaking, avoiding criticism, and even avoiding thinking about negative possibilities. While this avoidance felt like an easy option, it was, in reality, a tightening chain that made fear stronger and more controlling.

In the beginning, I told him calmly,

"We won't face the monster all at once. We'll take it step by step."

Gradual Exposure Steps:

1. **Step 1:** Practice presenting the project idea aloud in the therapy room, as a simple exercise to reduce fear by hearing his own voice.
2. **Step 2:** Record a voice clip of himself presenting the idea and review it to assess his performance.
3. **Step 3:** Create a three-minute video of himself discussing the project, focusing on body language, tone, and delivery.
4. **Step 4:** Use small notes as prompts during presentations to reduce anxiety about forgetting key points.
5. **Step 5:** Record feelings after each step, whether positive or negative, to analyze their impact.
6. **Step 6:** Repeat the exercises while practicing in front of a mirror and recording his voice at home to familiarize himself with his tone and delivery.

Over time, these exercises became a powerful tool for him to get used to the situation and reduce the fear of confrontation. He also adopted a healthier outlook toward others'

reactions. He reminded himself,
"I can't control how others react, but I can control doing my best and viewing criticism as an opportunity to learn, not as a rejection."

Step 4: Identifying Core Beliefs

As therapy progressed, it became clear that the panic attacks were merely the tip of the iceberg. Beneath the surface lay core beliefs about himself and the world, such as:
"If I show my vulnerability, no one will love me."

When I asked him where this belief originated, he returned to his childhood:
"I remember my father always saying men don't cry. I thought showing emotions meant I was less brave or more fragile."

We began to reevaluate this false belief. I asked him to reflect on moments where he expressed his emotions openly without losing others' respect.

He recalled how his wife had always supported and encouraged him to express himself without hesitation. He also realized that his close friends had never seen him as weak for sharing his feelings; instead, they admired his ambition, kindness, and continuous success in both his personal and professional life.

This reflection was transformative. He began to see that the fear controlling him was merely a barrier blocking him from recognizing his achievements and resilience.

We replaced the negative belief with a healthier, more positive one:
"Expressing my emotions makes me more human, not less valuable. I am successful, and I've overcome many challenges before—I'll continue to succeed as I always have."

Step 5: Realistic Evaluation of Situations

One deeply rooted factor behind his fear was his tendency to treat assumptions as facts. He often interpreted others' actions as personal judgments against him.

For instance, he once said,
"I felt like my colleague was ignoring me because he thinks I'm weak."

This idea had become a fixed "truth" in his mind, fueling his anxiety and self-doubt.

I asked him to analyze the situation with me, separating facts from assumptions:

- **Facts:** His colleague was busy and couldn't respond to his message.
- **Assumptions:** "He hates me and thinks I'm weak."

After a moment of thought, he said,
"Maybe he wasn't ignoring me; maybe he was genuinely busy."

This realization was a small but significant step in breaking the cycle of negative thinking.

The Profound Impact of Change

Over the weeks, he began noticing changes in his daily life. The panic attacks that once terrified him no longer held the same power—they became moments of challenge he could handle.

In one of our final sessions, he entered the room with a confident smile and said,
"I've started seeing things more clearly. I now know I'm not weak. Fear doesn't define me—how I deal with it does."

These words encapsulated his journey—from someone running from his fears to someone facing them with confidence. Negative thoughts no longer dominated him, and he could use difficult experiences as opportunities to learn and grow rather than threats to his self-worth.

A Message for You

This story is more than a patient's experience—it's a human journey. Each step was filled with challenges, but also hope. Through journaling, analysis, gradual exposure, and exploring core beliefs, this patient broke free from the chains of fear and discovered his true strength.

CBT isn't just a set of techniques, it's a path to self-understanding and building a freer, more fulfilling life.

What's Next?

In Chapter Four, we'll dive deeper into managing difficult emotions that often stem from negative thoughts and core beliefs. We'll explore emotions like anxiety, anger, and sadness—not as enemies to fight but as messages with meaning and lessons to learn from.

You'll discover strategies for dissecting these emotions, understanding their roots, and transforming them into tools for growth. We'll also discuss practical techniques for managing anxiety, such as relaxation exercises and redirecting attention, and ways to channel anger into positive energy rather than letting it become destructive.

Chapter Four

Mastering the Art of Emotional Regulation

The human face, as described by Dr. Paul Ekman, is the "window to the mind," revealing every detail of our thoughts and emotions to those around us. However, we can transform this window into a neutral canvas that reflects wisdom instead of impulsivity, and composure instead of turmoil.

Emotional control is crucial, especially when dealing with toxic personalities. Toxic individuals thrive on provoking others, as it gives them a false sense of power. Deep down, they often harbor feelings of inadequacy or emptiness, which they attempt to fill by eliciting strong emotional reactions from others. Seeing anger or frustration in others validates their sense of control, masking their inner weaknesses.

For toxic individuals, emotional reactions serve as both sustenance for their fragile egos and weapons to hide their own fears. However, mastering emotional control can protect you from falling into their trap, reclaiming your sense of inner peace.

Anger and Anxiety: Two Faces of Lost Control

Although anger and anxiety may appear to pull in opposite directions, they share a common outcome: both represent a loss of emotional control, leading to inner turmoil.

Anger

Described by Dr. Gabor Maté as "the fire that burns within us when we feel injustice," anger is a powerful, primal emotion that mobilizes the body and mind to confront a real or perceived threat. It is a natural reaction designed to protect us.

At the heart of this response lies the **amygdala**, a small almond-shaped part of the brain. When the amygdala perceives a threat, it triggers an internal alarm, activating the fight-or-flight response.

This response accelerates the heartbeat, increases blood flow to muscles, and sharpens focus—all preparing the body to either confront the threat or escape it. While this mechanism was vital for survival in ancient times, it often becomes a chronic state in modern life, especially when the source of anger is emotional or psychological rather than a tangible danger.

Anxiety

Anxiety, on the other hand, is the cold shadow that seeps into the mind, occupying hidden corners and drowning it in fears of the unknown. Like anger, anxiety manipulates the body and mind, releasing stress hormones and putting us in constant confrontation with ourselves.

While anger rages like an unrelenting storm, anxiety creeps in like a heavy mist, yet both rob us of balance and inner peace.

Regaining control over these emotions is essential to restoring stability and transforming them into constructive forces that strengthen the mind and calm the spirit.

Scientific Strategies to Manage Anger and Anxiety

1. Controlling Facial Expressions

Research shows that controlling facial expressions requires a combination of conscious effort and rational thinking. According to Dr. Paul Ekman, facial micro expressions are involuntary and reveal our true emotions before we can consciously suppress them. However, with consistent practice, it's possible to minimize or even conceal these expressions entirely.

Muscle Relaxation Exercise for Facial Control

This exercise helps reduce muscle tension in the face, particularly in areas like the forehead, eyes, and mouth, where emotions often manifest.

Steps to Perform the Exercise:

1. Choose the right time and place:

- Find a quiet spot where you can sit or stand comfortably in front of a mirror.
- Ensure you have enough time to practice without feeling rushed.

2. Adopt a comfortable posture:

- Sit or stand with a straight back.
- Make sure your face is visible in the mirror for clear observation of expressions.

3. Focus on the forehead:

- Look at your forehead in the mirror and notice any tension or lines.
- Take a deep breath, focusing on relaxing the muscles in this area.
- Slowly raise your eyebrows, then lower them while imagining the tension melting away.

4. Relax the eyes:

- Observe the muscles around your eyes. Are they tight or strained?
- Close your eyes slowly for five seconds, then open them while visualizing tension leaving the area.

5. Soften the mouth and jaw:

- Check if you're clenching your teeth or tightening your jaw.
- Gently open your mouth slightly, then close it slowly, focusing on releasing any tightness.

6. Review your face:

- Take a final look at your face in the mirror. Does it appear calm and relaxed?

7. Repeat regularly:

- Practice this exercise daily for 5–10 minutes, increasing the duration if necessary.

2. Deep Breathing Exercise: The 4-7-8 Technique

This breathing technique, developed by Dr. Andrew Weil, calms the nervous system and helps manage emotional outbursts by synchronizing breath patterns to induce relaxation.

Steps to Perform the Technique:

1. Find a comfortable position:

- Sit or lie down in a quiet place with your back straight.

2. Set your focus:

- Close your eyes if it helps you concentrate. Place the tip of your tongue against the roof of your mouth, just behind your front teeth, and keep it there throughout the exercise.

3. Follow these steps:

- **Inhale (4 seconds):** Slowly breathe in through your nose for a count of four, filling your belly with air.
- **Hold (7 seconds):** Hold your breath for a count of seven, allowing your body to absorb calm energy.

- **Exhale (8 seconds):** Exhale fully and slowly through your mouth for a count of eight, producing a soft whooshing sound.

4. Repeat:

- Perform three cycles, gradually increasing to five as you become more comfortable.

Tips for Use:

- In sudden stressful moments, use this technique to quickly regain composure.
- Practice before bed to improve sleep quality.
- Use discreetly during social situations or meetings to manage emotional responses.

3. Mindfulness Meditation: Your Gateway to Mental Calm

What is Mindfulness Meditation?

Introduced by Dr. Jon Kabat-Zinn, mindfulness involves focusing entirely on the present moment without judgment. It's about observing thoughts and emotions like passing clouds, without clinging to or resisting them.

Steps to Practice Mindfulness Meditation:

1. Choose your space:

- Find a peaceful spot, whether at home, in a park, or at work.

2. Adopt a position:

- Sit with a straight back on a chair or cushion, or lie down comfortably.

3. Focus on your breath:

- Notice the sensation of air entering through your nose and exiting through your mouth.
- If your mind wanders, gently guide it back to your breath.

4. Acknowledge distractions:

- Instead of resisting thoughts, acknowledge them, let them pass, and refocus on your breathing.

Benefits of Mindfulness:

- Reduces emotional reactivity.
- Improves focus and clarity.
- Enhances overall emotional resilience.

4. Observing the Senses

1. Hearing:

Close your eyes or keep them gently open, and direct your attention to the sounds around you. Start with the closest sounds, such as your breathing or the rustling of your clothes. Then expand your awareness to include more distant sounds: the wind moving through trees, birds chirping, the hum of cars in the distance, or even the noise of daily life. Notice the variations in the intensity, rhythm, and overlap of these sounds. Do not classify them as "good" or "bad"; simply let them be a part of your present awareness without resistance or control.

2. Sight:

If your eyes are open, slowly focus on what you see in front of you. Observe the colors and their gradients, the shapes and their edges, and how light reflects on different surfaces. You might notice the gentle swaying of trees, the glow of the sun behind clouds, or intricate details on a nearby wall. If your eyes are closed, imagine what might be around you based on your sense of space. Let your gaze wander naturally without lingering on or judging anything you see.

3. Touch:

Pay attention to the physical sensations of your body in its environment. How does your body feel against the chair or the ground? Do you feel the warmth or coolness of the air on your skin? Run your fingers over nearby surfaces: the texture of fabric, wood, or even your own skin. Notice the smoothness or roughness, warmth or coolness, and the weight or lightness of objects. Be fully aware of your physical presence without trying to change anything.

4. Smell:

Direct your attention to the scents around you, even if they are faint or barely noticeable. Is there the aroma of flowers, grass, or fresh air? Perhaps you catch the scent of nearby food

or a waft of perfume in the air. If you're indoors, there might be subtle smells from furniture, paper, or fabrics. Breathe deeply and slowly, allowing the scents to become part of your experience without labeling them as pleasant or unpleasant. Simply notice them as they are.

5. Taste:

If you are eating or drinking, immerse yourself fully in the experience. How does the taste develop the moment the food touches your tongue? Is it sweet, salty, sour, bitter, or umami? Pay attention to how the flavor changes with each bite or sip. If you're not eating, notice the natural taste in your mouth—perhaps it feels dry, moist, or carries traces of a previous meal.

Be Present with Yourself and Let Thoughts Pass

- It's natural for your mind to wander during meditation. Don't judge yourself or feel frustrated if you notice your thoughts drifting elsewhere.
- Instead of resisting or trying to stop the thoughts, imagine them as clouds in the sky; they come and go without you holding on to or clinging to them.
- Acknowledge the thought, then gently redirect your focus to your breathing or the sense you've chosen to concentrate on.

If a thought about work or a troubling issue arises, say to yourself kindly:

"I see this thought... it will pass like the clouds do."

Then return to observing your breath.

Returning to the Moment

- When you realize your mind has drifted into a cycle of thoughts, don't resist it. Use a gentle tone with yourself and refocus your attention on the present.
- You can use internal reminders like:
 - "Return to the moment."
 - "I am here now."
 - "I focus on my breath."
- Repeat these phrases calmly and without haste. The goal is to notice the drift and gently redirect your attention without judgment.

Benefits of Mindful Meditation

1. Interrupting Negative Thinking:

- Help break the cycle of negative thoughts that can lead to stress or anxiety.
- Dr. Kabat-Zinn notes that mindfulness meditation provides the mind with "space to breathe," offering clarity in thought.

2. Increased Self-Awareness:

- You become more aware of your emotions, thoughts, and responses to situations, enabling you to manage undesirable reactions.

3. Stress Reduction:

- Mindful meditation calms the nervous system, helping to alleviate stress.

4. Improved Focus:

- With practice, it becomes easier to concentrate on daily tasks without distractions.

Where to Apply Mindfulness in Daily Life

- **While Walking:** Notice your steps, their sound, and what surrounds you.
- **While Eating:** Focus on the flavor, aroma, and texture of your food.
- **In Challenging Situations:** Use mindfulness to calm yourself before reacting.

Quick Exercises to Reset Nerves in 10 Seconds

1. 4-2-4 Breathing Exercise:

- Inhale slowly through your nose for 4 seconds, feeling your lungs fill with air.
- Hold your breath gently for 2 seconds.
- Exhale slowly through your mouth for 4 seconds, imagining tension leaving with the breath.
- Repeat as needed for further relaxation.

2. Mindful Touch Exercise:

- Place your hand gently on your chest or stomach.
- Apply light pressure and feel the warmth of your hand against your body.
- Take a deep breath through your nose, focusing on the sensation of warmth and safety.
- Exhale slowly through your mouth, imagining tension leaving with the breath.

3. Conscious Countdown Exercise:

- Take a deep breath through your nose and hold it for a second.
- Slowly count down from 5 to 1 in your mind:
 - **5:** Relax your shoulders.
 - **4:** Relax your jaw and face.
 - **3:** Relax your hands and fingers.
 - **2:** Relax your chest and abdomen.
 - **1:** Relax your legs and feet.
- Exhale slowly through your mouth as you finish.

Note:

You can use any of these exercises whenever you feel stressed or anxious. These simple yet effective tools can help you regain calm and focus on just a few moments.

Emotional Regulation in Psychology

Neutral Facial Expressions: A Psychological Skill Beyond Influence

According to studies from Harvard University, maintaining a neutral and calm facial expression does more than convey external composure—it impacts the mind and body internally. Neutral expressions send positive signals to the brain, reinforcing a sense of control, which in turn calms the nervous system and reduces stress.

How Does a Neutral Face Impact Others?

1. In Negotiations:

- Maintaining calm facial expressions gives you a psychological advantage. When your face doesn't show worry or emotion, the other party may feel unsettled or doubt their position, making them more likely to offer concessions.

2. In Arguments:

- In heated debates, a neutral face helps diffuse tension in the other person. When you respond to shouting or provocation with a calm, steady expression, it creates a sense of futility in escalating the conflict.

3. In Leadership and Social Settings:

- Leaders who maintain steady facial expressions are perceived as more competent and confident, which enhances their ability to inspire and reassure others.

Additional Exercises to Improve Facial Expression Control

1. Mirror Exercises:

- **Description:**

Stand in front of a mirror and practice displaying various emotions such as anger, happiness, or anxiety. Then gradually reduce the intensity of these expressions while maintaining a neutral face.

- **Purpose:** This exercise helps you become aware of the muscles that move during emotional expressions, enabling better control in real-life situations.

2. Self-Recording:

- **Description:**

Simulate a potentially stressful or provocative situation and record yourself responding to it.

- **Purpose:** Review the recording to identify moments when your emotions surface. Pay attention to which facial muscles or expressions need more control.

3. Positive Visualization:

- **Description:**
Imagine yourself in a challenging scenario, such as confronting an angry person or negotiating a sensitive matter. Focus on maintaining a calm and neutral facial expression during this mental exercise.
 - **Purpose:** This practice allows you to prepare mentally and physically for real-world situations, training your face and mind to remain composed.

In Conclusion

As Marcus Aurelius once said:

"Let no one disturb your inner peace; it is your only sanctuary."

Facial expression control is not just a social skill—it is a reflection of inner strength. In a world full of pressures and conflicts, a neutral face is more than an external reflection; it is a silent message that declares:

"I am here. I am the master of myself. No storm will sway me."

With practice, you will find that this skill becomes more than a tool for interacting with others—it becomes a lifestyle that enhances your sense of calm and self-control.

Threat: Reality or Illusion?

Now, let's delve into a critical point closely tied to our previous discussion on negative emotions, particularly anger and anxiety. Living within the confines of an unhealthy relationship is often an exhausting experience for both the mind and spirit. The individual feels trapped under a constant weight of fear and anticipation.

This fear creeps in gradually, fostering a sense of emotional and psychological insecurity that makes the person feel as though they are perpetually under threat, unable to escape.

Often, this fear stems from the dynamics of the relationship itself, where **threats are used as tools of control** if the other person genuinely has the power to cause harm. But does this threat truly reflect a real capability, or is it merely an illusion planted in the mind to keep the person submissive and perpetually anxious?

In the following paragraphs, we will explore the true nature of threats. Do they translate into actual harm, or are they just psychological games used for manipulation in toxic and unhealthy relationships? We will examine the underlying causes of these emotions and dismantle the illusion to gain a deeper understanding of how threats impact our daily lives and behaviors.

Case Study: The Illusion of Threat in a Toxic Marriage

Toxic relationships, including marriages, often involve threats and emotional exploitation. The following story is no exception. It is a true account, retold briefly to maintain the anonymity of names and location.

While many men experience emotional threats in relationships, this example highlights the journey of a woman we will call *Fadia*. Her story is one of enduring years of fear instilled by her husband through manipulation and emotional threats.

Through this narrative, we will explore the dynamics of control and fear and seek to uncover the psychological mechanisms behind the illusion of threat in toxic relationships.

Fadia: When Weakness Faces the Mask of Strength

Fadia was a woman in her mid-thirties, with calm features and a confident smile. Yet behind this composed façade lay hidden pains that never saw the light. To others, she appeared the perfect wife, managing her home with wisdom and selfless sacrifice. Only she knew that this outward calmness was a veil concealing a life that drained her from within. Her marriage was a deceptive social front, as she was married to a man adept at emotional manipulation and reshaping reality to suit his desires.

For years, her husband skillfully crafted a perfect image in front of family and friends, portraying himself as a loving father and devoted husband. In private, however, he employed psychological tactics that kept Fadia trapped in a maze of continuous threats and emotional blackmail. He understood her vulnerabilities, particularly her fear of losing her children, and wielded this fear as a weapon to exert complete control over her life. He repeatedly used phrases that made her feel powerless:

"You can't survive without me... no one will accept you if you leave me."

His threats weren't merely passing remarks; they were intricately woven manipulations that made Fadia feel as if she were cornered with no escape. She lived in an emotional prison—one whose doors weren't locked by reality but by the illusory chains of fear and self-doubt.

Dismantling the Illusion: Unveiling the Truth

When Fadia began sharing the details of her life with me, what struck me most was her conviction that her husband's threats were absolute truths, not open to question. I calmly asked her,

"Have you ever considered the reality of these threats?"

She looked at me with surprise, as if hearing the question for the first time.

We started dismantling these threats one by one, turning what seemed like immutable facts into hypotheses open for analysis:

1. Child Custody:

Could her husband actually take the children from her? According to custody laws, it is not easy for anyone to deprive a mother of her children, especially when they are young. This would require complex legal procedures and proof that he could handle their emotional and financial needs, which didn't align with his irresponsible lifestyle.

2. Parental Responsibility:

I asked her,

"How does he handle the children in your daily life? Is he a present father who consistently cares for them, or is his role limited to social appearances?"

She answered with a mix of sadness and newfound clarity:

"He takes them to the park occasionally and likes to show them off in front of the family, but he doesn't know the details of their daily lives."

3. Threat of Remarriage:

His frequent threats of remarriage loomed over her like a sword whenever she resisted. I asked her,

"If he marries someone else, will that end your life? Or could it mark the beginning of a new chapter for you, free from threats and constant humiliation?"

She paused, as if the question was reorganizing her thoughts.

I realized then that what kept her bound wasn't the threats themselves but her deeply ingrained belief that she had no other options. I told her,

"What if you confronted him with what he threatens you with? Say to him: Take the children if you can handle them on your own, and marry someone else if you wish. As for me, I will live my life as I want."

Her reaction was a mix of shock and fear, but she admitted something important:

"He can't do that... he barely spends time with them, and he can't handle their responsibilities on his own."

From Weakness to Strength

Gradually, Fadia began to see that what she had believed to be immutable truths were nothing, but illusions skillfully constructed by her husband to keep her under his control. This realization was not easy, it required breaking a deep psychological barrier, one fueled by years of manipulation and persistent fear.

She started implementing simple but effective strategies, such as focusing on her physical health and self-care—not just to improve her appearance but to rebuild the foundations of her confidence and inner strength.

After some time, Fadia returned and told me,
"When he threatened to take the children, I told him what you suggested... he was stunned, then resorted to shouting, threatening, and storming out of the house. But he couldn't hide his shock at my new reaction."

When her husband faced a woman no longer afraid of his threats, he shifted from intimidation to pleading, from yelling to emotional blackmail. He tried every tool of control he knew, but this time, he found himself confronting a different person, someone who had begun to see that his threats lost their power once she viewed them through a new lens that dismantled their illusions.

So, What Happened?

When Fadia decided to confront her husband's threats with confidence, even if initially feigned—she uncovered the weakness hiding behind the mask of strength he had worn for years. The confrontation revealed the mechanisms of psychological manipulation he had used against her, allowing her to clearly see that his threats relied on the fear he had planted within her, not on his actual ability to act.

Key Insights from Fadia's Journey

1. His Power Relied on Her Fear

A manipulator's authority stems from the other person's submission. They create a fabricated reality of power by instilling fear, avoiding real confrontation. What keeps them in control is not actual tools of enforcement but the belief that the other person accepts their threats and lives accordingly. Fadia's husband knew that the mere thought of losing her children was enough to paralyze her, so he repeated the same threat tirelessly, relying on its psychological impact.

2. Threats Are Easier Than Actions

Using threats is a cheap psychological tactic—words require minimal effort compared to actual implementation. For example, the threat of taking the children was merely a tool for control. He knew legal procedures were not simple. Emotional blackmail was his weapon because he knew that merely mentioning it was enough to exhaust her mentally, without having to face the burdens of actual responsibility.

3. Weakness Behind the Mask of Strength

Those who rely on threats are often inherently weak, fearing that their true selves

will be exposed. They need to continuously project control because letting go of this façade would mean losing their illusionary influence. Fadia's husband knew he couldn't handle the responsibilities of raising the children alone, yet he persisted in wearing the mask of strength—one that crumbled when Fadia stopped responding with fear and began challenging his threats with calm confidence.

4. Threats Reflect Internal Fears

What Fadia didn't initially realize was that the threats themselves were a reflection of her husband's deep fear of losing control over her. He knew that his authority depended on her submission. When she started to show emotional independence and stopped fearing his threats, his true fears became evident: isolation, loss of control, and facing responsibilities he was never prepared for.

A Message for Anyone Facing Threats

Threats, at their core, are nothing more than words designed to instill fear and restrict freedom. They are tools used by those who feel powerless to create an illusion of control. However, they only become reality if you believe in them and submit to them.

When you confront threats with awareness and calmness, their mask begins to fade, revealing the fragility of the one issuing them. A manipulator's power often lies in their loud voice and hurtful words, which conceal their fear of losing control. Their strength is not real; it stems from blind belief in their words and your retreat in response.

By challenging threats with clarity and courage, you reclaim your freedom and unveil the truth behind the illusion.

True Strength Lies in Your Reaction

- When you realize that a threat is merely a possible scenario, not an inevitable fate.
- When you stop overestimating what might happen and begin preparing for the worst, leaving fear with no place to hide.
- When you arm yourself with knowledge and awareness, creating alternative plans to be ready for what you fear, you become immune to psychological manipulation.

As Fadia said in her final session:

"I'm no longer afraid. I won't say I don't feel anxious at times, but now I know that my life isn't in my husband's hands; it's in mine."

Always remember that fear becomes a tool for the manipulator only when you grant them permission. Taking control of your reaction is the beginning of liberation, and simply recognizing this truth is the first step toward reclaiming your life.

What's Next?

In the next chapter, we will explore how to improve relationships using cognitive behavioral therapy techniques. You will learn how to build healthy relationships, manage conflicts, and use effective dialogue to enhance communication.

Chapter Five

Broken Trust and Building Healthy Relationships

Human relationships are the backbone of our lives—they bring us love and support but can also deliver disappointment and betrayal. They are a source of strength when balanced and healthy and a source of pain when marred by deceit or exploitation. When trust is broken, the pain becomes a deep wound that's hard to heal. Between the fear of repeating the experience and the hope of mending what's broken, we embark on a journey to rebuild healthy relationships.

Trust: The Fragile Element in Relationships

Hala and Her Friend: A One-Sided Relationship

Hala, a woman in her late twenties, entered the session with a mix of hesitation and betrayal in her words. As she recounted her story, it was as if she feared confronting a truth too heavy to bear. She looked at me with questioning eyes and said:

"She was everything to me. I shared every detail of my life with her, even things I didn't share with my family. But she betrayed me... she spoke badly about me to others, as if I meant nothing to her."

Her words carried a pain that went beyond betrayal; it was a shock to the trust Hala had carefully built, only to see it collapse unexpectedly.

I asked her in a calm voice, encouraging her to reflect:

"Did you ever feel that your relationship was unbalanced?"

She hesitated, as if confronting a question she had avoided for years, and then quietly replied:

"Maybe... but she was my friend. I didn't want to doubt her intentions."

Over time, we unraveled the threads of this relationship to discover that Hala had been giving endlessly. She was a constant source of emotional support, offering small gifts and prioritizing her friend over herself. Yet, in return, she received only scraps of attention.

I gently asked her:

"Were you aware of the value you brought to this relationship?"

She replied with sadness:

"I never thought about it. I just considered it normal."

Here, the truth became clear: Hala hadn't recognized her own worth or realized that friendship, like any other human relationship, requires a balance between giving and

receiving. Her belief that unconditional giving was the key to keeping a friendship alive blinded her to the signs of imbalance.

I looked at her and said:

"True relationships are not arenas for one-sided sacrifices. They are partnerships where both parties share in giving and caring. What happened wasn't just betrayal; it was an opportunity for you to reassess your value and what you deserve from others."

At that moment, Hala began to understand that healing wasn't just about overcoming betrayal but about recognizing her worth and setting boundaries to protect herself from relationships that drained her without reciprocity.

Noor and Her Husband: The Betrayal That Shook Trust

Noor, a young woman in her late twenties, entered the session as if carrying the weight of the world on her shoulders. Her eyes reflected a painful mix of anger and sorrow, as if searching for answers she couldn't find. She began speaking with a trembling voice:

"My husband admitted to his infidelity. He said it was just a fling and that he wants to start over. But I... I can't trust him. Every time he's late coming home, I feel like he's cheating again."

Her words conveyed more than the pain of betrayal; they revealed a collapse of trust—not just in her partner but in herself as well.

I gently asked her, leaving room for thought:

"Did you feel that something was off before discovering the affair?"

She was silent for a long time, as if revisiting moments she had buried within herself, and then said hesitantly:

"Maybe... he would wake up at night, claiming he couldn't sleep, and sit in the garden for hours. I knew he was on the phone, but he would hide it from me."

Her eyes drifted toward a past filled with details she had chosen to ignore. She continued, recalling more she had suppressed:

"He traveled often, especially on weekends. I justified it by saying he was busy with work. I felt something wasn't right, but I chose to stay silent, like many women do."

Noor wasn't just a victim of infidelity; she was a victim of the denial she had chosen to avoid confronting a painful truth. She lived the pattern many women follow—a pattern that dictates silence and acceptance.

I looked at her and said with gentle firmness:

"Noor, the betrayal didn't begin when your husband chose to be with someone else. It

began when you both stopped genuinely communicating. When silence became the language you spoke and when you chose to ignore your inner voice."

At that moment, Noor began to realize that her pain wasn't solely about her husband's betrayal. It was also about betraying her own inner voice, which had always tried to warn her. This realization marked the beginning of a new path—a path toward confrontation, healing, and rebuilding trust in herself, regardless of her future decisions.

Thamer: Isolation as a False Shield

Thamer, a man in his early forties, sat before me with eyes burdened by years of pain. He said:

"After my wife divorced me, I decided not to let anyone get close to me again. Why risk repeating the pain?"

I paused at his words and reflected on the wall he had built around his heart. I asked him gently:

"Has this decision made you happy?"

He ran his hand across his forehead, remaining silent for a long time before replying in a faint voice:

"No... but it made me feel safe."

At that moment, we began discussing the concept of true safety—one that stems from confronting fears—and false safety, which hides behind the mask of isolation. Gradually, his past unfolded: a childhood marred by his parents' conflicts, which filled him with fear of repeating the same experience with his children. He carried a deep pain but lacked the tools to confront it.

I looked at him for a moment and said:

"Relationships, Thamer, are like soil. If you don't give them a chance to grow, they remain barren... but when you nurture them, they bloom with flowers you never expected."

Through our conversations, Thamer began to see that isolation wasn't a shield protecting him but a prison confining him. He realized that confrontation wasn't an easy path but the only road to liberation from the chains of his past.

Steps to Rebuild Trust and Healthy Relationships

1. Healing from Within

Healthy relationships are reflections of the relationship we have with ourselves. Emotional wounds that remain unhealed turn into shadows that haunt us, pushing us—often

unconsciously—toward relationships that echo our pain rather than offer healing. These wounds act as distorted lenses through which we view the world and others. Thus, the journey to healing always begins deep within, where difficult yet essential confrontations take place.

I encouraged Noor, Hala, and Thamer to start writing in journals, as if unlocking doors that had been closed for years. I explained that writing isn't just about putting words on paper; it's a mirror reflecting their inner thoughts and feelings. As discussed in previous chapters, writing is a courageous act that brings suppressed emotions and scattered thoughts to light.

2. Gradually Facing Fears

Step One: Opening the Door to Simple Interactions

The initial step was engaging in simple conversations with new people, whether within their social circles or with strangers. These conversations didn't require depth or commitment at first; their purpose was to break the silence and create space for human connection. We likened this step to opening a small window through which relationships could look out onto a world of possibilities, without rushing to significant expectations.

After each experience, it was essential to reflect on the emotions and thoughts it evoked: Was the conversation easy or difficult? What feelings arose, and why? This wasn't merely an analysis of the interaction but an invitation to explore the internal fears and thoughts that might hinder such exchanges.

We often found that the difficulty didn't lie in the other person but in the internal fears rooted in past experiences.

Step Two: Expanding the Circle Through Group Activities

Once individual interactions became less daunting, we moved to the next step: participating in group activities. We chose environments that encouraged natural, meaningful interactions, such as volunteering or attending creative workshops. The aim wasn't merely participation but creating opportunities to interact with people who shared common values and interests.

The type of environment where people meet is crucial. Spaces aren't neutral; they play a significant role in shaping the quality of relationships and the nature of the people we engage with. Group activities act as mirrors of the shared values among participants.

For instance:

- **Volunteering** often attracts empathetic and open-minded individuals.

- **Workshops** foster collaboration and mutual learning.

By intentionally choosing the right environment, we aimed to build connections grounded in mutual values rather than mere chance.

Unlike online dating apps or superficial social media interactions, these in-person connections promote genuine communication and reduce the likelihood of emotional manipulation. Seeing the other person in their real-life setting provides clarity that virtual interactions often lack.

The Third Step: Continuous Evaluation and Building Trust

With every experience, evaluation was a pivotal step. Together, we analyzed these experiences—not just by recounting what happened but delving into the emotions and fears they triggered. Was there a fear of rejection? Did the other person seem disinterested? Or were the anxieties stemming from our own expectations?

The goal of evaluation was not merely to reduce fears but to reframe them. Instead of letting these fears become barriers, they became opportunities for deeper understanding of ourselves and others. We discovered that many of these fears were unfounded, often extensions of unresolved past experiences.

This step served as a stage for rebuilding trust—not only in others but also in oneself. Continuous evaluation helped individuals realize that relationships aren't built overnight and require patience and persistence. Through this process, everyone began to recognize that while the past is a significant part of their present self, it doesn't necessarily define the reality they are living in now. There is ample opportunity to mitigate the impact of past experiences and lessen their intensity on one's psyche.

3. Improving Communication: Building Bridges of Understanding and Trust

Strong relationships are not just built on interaction but heavily rely on the quality of communication. Enhancing communication skills means creating a space where everyone feels heard and their emotions understood. To achieve this, we focused on two main skills: **active listening** and **using “I-statements,”** incorporating examples to demonstrate their effective application.

Active Listening: The Art of Being Fully Present

Listening is not merely about hearing words; it's about being fully present with the other person and showing genuine interest in what they're saying without interrupting or rushing

to respond. When we listen deeply, we send a message to the other person that they matter and that their thoughts and feelings are valued.

In our therapy sessions, we trained individuals to stop thinking about their automatic responses while the other person was talking and to listen without interrupting. A key part of active listening was expressing empathy through phrases that reflect understanding, such as:

"I understand that you're feeling frustrated. How can I help?"

We began with simple, everyday scenarios and encouraged participants to practice active listening in their daily lives. The biggest challenge was resisting the urge to offer quick fixes or defend themselves, as they often had in the past, and instead committing to creating space for the other person to feel heard.

Using "I-Statements": Expressing Feelings Clearly Without Blame

In relationships, strong emotions often transform into unintended accusations, leading to tension and conflicts. For this reason, we focused on developing the skill of using "I-statements" as a way to express feelings without assigning blame.

For example, instead of saying:

"You ignore my messages because you don't care about me."

—which carries an implicit accusation likely to make the other person defensive—participants learned to rephrase it as:

"I feel frustrated when I don't receive a response to my messages."

This approach allows individuals to express their needs clearly and honestly while focusing on personal feelings rather than blaming the other person. The result? A calmer, more respectful dialogue that enables both parties to understand each other's perspectives without feeling threatened.

Message for You:

Trust is not an easy path, but it is worth the effort. It is a choice born of the realization that pain is part of life but not its end. When we begin to heal ourselves, we become capable of building healthy relationships that reflect our values and needs.

As Noor said at the end of her sessions:

"Perhaps I won't trust easily again, but I now understand that I deserve a relationship built on respect and honesty."

What's Next?

In the next chapter, we will discuss how to establish boundaries in relationships and how to use them as tools for protection and effective communication—without turning them into walls that hinder love and understanding.

Chapter Seven

Self-Confidence and Self-Awareness – A Journey to Discover Your Truth

Dear Reader,

Within each of us lies a child carrying memories of words and sounds that have left an indelible mark. These words might be praises like: "You're amazing!" or reproaches like: "Why can't you be like others?" Or even harsh criticisms such as: "You'll never succeed if you keep this up."

These words aren't mere fleeting sounds; they are seeds planted deep within us. Some have grown into steadfast trees that empower us, while others have become thorns that hinder our progress.

Our journey in this chapter isn't just about boosting self-confidence or trying to satisfy the outside world; it's a deeper journey into self-discovery. It's about unearthing the layers of the past, freeing ourselves from the constraints of others' expectations, and living a life that reflects our truth—not theirs.

1. The Difference Between Self-Confidence and Self-Awareness

You might ask yourself, "Why do I need to understand this difference? Isn't self-confidence enough?"

The answer lies in the depth of what that confidence holds. A person might appear confident to others, possessing a charismatic presence and impactful words, yet inside, they may feel fragile, unsettled, and reliant on external validation to affirm their existence.

Self-Confidence: A Reflection of the Outer World

Self-confidence is often tied to how others perceive our successes, achievements, and outward appearance. It relies on continuous nourishment from the surrounding environment. The more praise we receive or the more recognition we gain, the stronger our confidence becomes. But what happens when the praise stops or when we face harsh criticism?

The Story of Sarah: The Fragile Glass of External Confidence

Sarah, a young woman in her late twenties, possessed striking beauty and a strong presence. In her circles, she was always in the spotlight, showered with compliments and admired by everyone around her. This gave her the feeling of walking on a cloud of confidence.

One day during a break at work, while chatting with colleagues, someone casually remarked, “You’re really beautiful, but if you had a nose job, you’d look even better.” It was an offhand comment, but it struck her like an arrow. The words pierced the composed image she had of herself. Suddenly, her nose, which had always been a natural part of her features, seemed like a major flaw. “Has everyone noticed this while I remained oblivious?”

Sarah spiraled into self-doubt. Each time she looked in the mirror, all she could see was the “flaw” that the passing remark had pointed out. She began analyzing people’s gazes, wondering: “Do they look at me because I’m beautiful, or because they notice what now torments me?”

Her inner turmoil became undeniable. She spent hours browsing cosmetic surgery websites, watching videos about rhinoplasty, and comparing her features to those of celebrities. “Maybe if I did this, I’d be prettier and more acceptable,” she thought.

The issue, however, wasn’t just about her nose. The comment planted doubts not only about her features but about her intrinsic value. Sarah felt that her beauty and the love and acceptance of others depended solely on her appearance.

During a therapy session, Sarah candidly expressed her pain: “I feel like I’ve been living a lie. I thought I was beautiful and confident, but now I realize my confidence was entirely dependent on others. Their admiration was like the mirror through which I saw myself. When that mirror cracked, I lost sight of who I was.”

Her words revealed the fragility of confidence derived from external validation. When asked what she saw in the mirror now, she replied tearfully, “I see someone desperately trying to be enough in others’ eyes.”

2. Khaled’s Story: The Shadow of Comparison and the Impact of Childhood on Self-Awareness

Khaled, a man in his forties, was the successful owner of a thriving tech company. From the outside, he seemed to have achieved everything one could dream of: wealth, respect, and a prominent social standing. But deep inside, he felt a persistent sense of inadequacy—a vague whisper telling him: “You’re not good enough.”

Sitting across from me, Khaled appeared emotionally drained despite his calm smile. “I don’t get it,” he said in a hoarse voice. “I’ve achieved things many people only dream of. So why do I always feel like I’m not enough?”

We delved into his past, searching for the roots of this constant sense of inadequacy. I asked him about his childhood and his relationship with his family. Taking a deep breath, memories began surfacing.

“I was the youngest of my siblings, and my older brother was the standard by which everyone was measured. He excelled in school, was athletically talented, and the ideal son in my parents’ eyes. I tried so hard to be like him, but I always felt like I fell short.”

Khaled remembered his mother’s well-meaning remarks: “Why can’t you be like your brother? He’s always first in everything.” These words, intended as motivation, became a double-edged sword, turning the comparison into a shadow that followed him everywhere.

“When I brought home my report card, excited to show my mother, she would say, ‘Good, but your brother got higher grades at your age.’ I felt like I could never meet the standard.”

This feeling became ingrained in him, shaping his identity. Every achievement in his professional life was measured against what his brother might have done or what others expected. He couldn’t see his worth outside of these constant comparisons.

When he graduated from university, Khaled decided to start his own business, aiming to prove himself—to the world and to himself. Despite the successes he achieved, that inner voice didn’t change.

“Even when I earned my first million, I felt it wasn’t enough. I’d heard that my brother had bought a new house and started thinking about how I could outdo him. But no matter what I did, I never felt satisfied.”

When I asked if he had ever shared these feelings with his brother, he smiled bitterly and said, “No, I haven’t. In fact, our relationship is superficial now. I think I distanced myself from him because of these comparisons. But maybe he never even realized how I felt.”

Khaled realized the problem wasn’t his brother but the image he had formed in his mind since childhood. The comparisons his mother had unintentionally instilled became part of his thought process.

I gently told him, “You know, the true comparison isn’t between you and others—it’s between who you are today and who you want to be tomorrow. Everyone has their own journey, and the measure of success differs from one person to another.”

Over time, Khaled began to understand that his relentless pursuit of outshining others was robbing him of the joy of what he had already accomplished. He had been living in a race with no finish line, where the endpoint kept moving.

“How do I free myself from this feeling?” he asked, his eyes filled with hope and hesitation.

“The beginning,” I replied, “is acknowledging that your value doesn’t depend on comparisons with others. Celebrate your achievements without measuring them against someone else’s. Allow yourself to feel proud of what you’ve done. And most importantly, try to rebuild your relationship with your brother—not as a rival, but as a sibling.”

Conclusion:

Khaled's story highlights how simple words spoken in childhood can leave deep imprints that last for decades. Constant comparison with others prevents us from seeing our true worth and robs us of the ability to enjoy our achievements.

Self-awareness begins when we decide to look inward and ask ourselves: "What do I want? What makes me happy?" Instead of: "What do others expect of me?" or "How can I be better than others?"

3. Noura's Story: From Medicine to Design – A Journey Toward Inner Independence

Noura, a woman in her mid-thirties, entered my office with a shy smile that concealed something heavier than words could express. She began, "I'm a successful doctor—everyone says so. But... does success mean happiness? Because I don't feel it."

Her words carried a profound internal struggle. I asked her gently, "If medicine isn't making you happy, why did you choose this field?"

Taking a deep breath, she answered with what felt like a confession: "I didn't choose it. My mother dreamed of this path for me. I was the eldest daughter, and she believed my success as a doctor would bring great pride to the family. I didn't want to disappoint her, so I followed what she wanted for me, not what I wanted for myself."

From a young age, Noura was an obedient child. She grew up hearing phrases like: "Success in school is the most important thing." "If you become a doctor, you'll live a respectable life." These weren't just parental guidelines; they became internal doctrines. Noura felt her mother's approval depended entirely on her achieving this dream.

Indeed, Noura excelled academically and entered medical school. She didn't feel overwhelming joy but convinced herself: "This is the right path. When I succeed, I'll feel fulfilled." But that feeling never came.

After years of hard work and perseverance, Noura secured a prestigious position as a doctor. Yet, she felt something was missing. She didn't enjoy her work and felt disconnected from the field she had struggled to enter. She admitted, "Every day, I go to work carrying a heavy burden. I love helping patients, but I don't feel like I belong here."

What made matters more complicated was the guilt she carried. She constantly asked herself, "Am I a bad person if I decide to leave medicine? What will my family think? What will my mother say?"

The pivotal moment came when Noura's father passed away suddenly. She said, "It was like a wake-up call. I realized life is too short. If I keep walking this path just to please others, I'll never live my life the way I want."

One night, while aimlessly browsing the internet, she came across an advertisement for an interior design course. Something about it resonated with her. She remembered her love for arranging rooms at home as a child and how happy she felt adding her personal touch to any space. Design had been her true passion, buried under the weight of others' expectations.

Noura made a bold decision. She enrolled in the course and started studying interior design in her free time. It wasn't an easy decision. She faced heavy criticism from her family, especially her mother, who said: "You're wasting years of hard work and success. How can you give it all up?"

But this time, Noura didn't back down. She began to see her life from a different perspective. She told me, "For the first time, I felt I was choosing for myself. I was scared, yes, but there was also a sense of freedom."

Over time, Noura found balance. She started taking on small design projects, and gradually, her work gained recognition.

4. How to Reshape Your Beliefs?

Mazn's Story: Breaking the Chains

Mazn, a man in his early thirties, lived his life surrounded by invisible walls. He preferred working quietly, avoided large meetings, and felt most comfortable in the shadows, away from the spotlight. However, he carried a heavy burden of perpetual inadequacy. During one session, he told me, "I can't speak in front of people. It's just not in my nature."

When we began delving into his experiences, I asked him about the first time he felt this fear. After some thought, he hesitantly said, "It was in school. I was ten years old, and my teacher asked me to give a speech in front of the class. I was terrified, stumbled over my words, and some classmates laughed. I've never forgotten that moment."

That moment wasn't just a passing incident in Mazn's childhood; it was a small seed planted deep inside him. Over time, it grew into a deeply ingrained belief: "I'm not good at public speaking."

Over the years, this belief became a chain that dictated Mazn's choices. He avoided jobs requiring strong communication skills, declined invitations to give speeches at family events, and even turned down work presentations despite being one of the best employees. He said, "I feel like all eyes are on me. If I make one small mistake, everything will fall apart."

What Mazn didn't realize was that the incident from his childhood wasn't a definitive judgment of his abilities. It was just one experience. But his mind, like any human mind, took that experience and turned it into an all-encompassing rule: "I'm a failure at public speaking."

Things changed when a close friend asked him to give a speech at his wedding. Initially, Mazn vehemently refused: "I can't do it. Pick someone else." But his friend's insistence made him reconsider. Knowing how important this moment was to his friend, he decided to try, despite his fear.

Mazn began preparing for the speech. He was scared as he wrote it but persisted. He practiced in front of a mirror, his wife, and even his young children. With each attempt, a voice inside him echoed, "You can do this."

When the wedding day arrived, Mazn's heart raced as if all his old fears had resurfaced. But he stood before the audience and began to speak. His words faltered at first, but he kept going. With each sentence, he saw people smiling and realized they were listening attentively. When he finished, he was met with loud applause and felt something he hadn't experienced in years: pride.

In the next session, he said with a shy smile, "For the first time, I realized I had been carrying a chain that wasn't real. It was all in my head."

Conclusion

Mazn's story shows how one belief, based on a single experience, can limit our entire lives. It also shows how we can break that chain if we're willing to challenge ourselves. Mazn didn't overcome his fear overnight, but he took a small step toward change and discovered that the strength he sought wasn't outside him—it had been within him all along.

Just like Mazn, we all carry self-imposed limitations rooted in past experiences. But the simple truth is: these chains only have power over us if we allow them to. Remember, the strength to free yourself lies within. All it takes is that first step.

Practical Exercises: Building Self-Confidence and Self-Awareness

1. The Inner and Outer Confidence Exercise

This exercise helps you differentiate between what fuels your confidence from the external world and what originates internally. It's a first step to understanding what sustains you permanently versus what weakens you when it's absent.

Steps

1. Choose a quiet place:

- Sit in a comfortable spot where you can think without interruptions. You may need a notebook and a pen to record your thoughts.

2. Divide a page in half:

- Write on the first half: *“What makes me feel confident in front of others?”*
 - Think about the things that make you feel at ease when interacting with people.
 - Example: Your academic achievements, physical appearance, or professional accomplishments.
- Write on the second half: *“What do I believe about myself when I’m alone?”*
 - Ask yourself: *Do I feel enough? Do I love myself despite flaws? Do I believe I have value even when I achieve nothing?*

3. Reflect and compare:

- Look at the answers in both columns.
- Observe whether most of your confidence comes from external sources or internal beliefs.
- If you find that most of your answers rely on external validation, this indicates a need to work on self-awareness.
- If they stem from internal judgment, you are on a good path to sustaining your confidence.

Develop the Exercise:

- Write one thing daily that reflects your appreciation for yourself without relying on others’ opinions.
 - Example: *“I love my logical thinking,”* or *“I value my patience in challenging situations.”*

2. Reviewing Old Beliefs

This exercise helps you understand how certain beliefs about yourself were formed and how to reshape them into more supportive and positive ones.

Steps

1. Recall childhood memories:

- Sit with yourself and rethink the words you heard often during your childhood.
- Example: *“Why can’t you be like so-and-so?” or “You’re smart!” or “You’ll never achieve anything.”*
- Don’t evaluate the words yet; just write them down.

2. Classify the words as positive or negative:

- Put a (+) next to words that uplift and encourage you.
- Put a (–) next to words that make you feel discouraged or inadequate.

3. Ask yourself deep questions:

- *“Does this statement reflect my truth now?”*
- *“Who said it? Were they right?”*
- *“How has this statement influenced my decisions and behaviors later?”*

4. Replace negative statements with positive ones:

- Choose one impactful negative statement.
- Replace it with a positive statement that reflects your current reality.
- Example: If you hold the statement *“I’m a failure,”* replace it with *“I may face challenges, but I’m always learning and improving.”*

Develop the Exercise:

- Repeat the new positive statement daily in front of a mirror or write it where you can see it regularly.

3. Building Independence from Others’ Influence

This exercise helps you identify activities and thoughts that genuinely represent you versus those you perform solely to please others.

Steps

1. Record your daily activities:

- At the end of each day, write down everything you did throughout the day.

2. Classify them:

- Place a (✓) next to activities you did because you genuinely enjoyed or wanted to do them.
- Place an (×) next to activities you did only to please others.

3. Evaluate the impact of each type of activity:

- Next to each activity, write how you felt while doing it and afterward.
- Notice if the activities you perform to please others drain your energy more than they give you.

4. Begin changing gradually:

- Choose one activity you do only to please others.
- Ask yourself: *“Can I reduce this activity or replace it with something I enjoy doing?”*
- Example: If you feel obligated to attend every social gathering, start saying “no” occasionally to events you don’t wish to attend.

Develop the Exercise:

- After two weeks, review your list and note how your choices have changed. Have you started prioritizing yourself?

4. Reshaping Negative Thoughts

This exercise helps you deconstruct negative thoughts you have about yourself and replace them with more positive ones.

Steps

1. Identify a recurring negative thought:

- Ask yourself: *“What negative thought frequently crosses my mind?”*
- Example: *“I always fail at everything.”*

2. Write evidence supporting this thought:

- Think of real-life examples that support the thought.
- Example: *“I couldn’t pass a particular exam.”*

3. Write evidence contradicting this thought:

- Look for examples that refute this belief.

- Example: *“I’ve succeeded in other exams before.”*

4. **Replace the thought with a new statement:**

- Tell yourself: *“This thought wasn’t true all the time.”*
- *“I learn from my mistakes, and that makes me stronger.”*

Develop the Exercise:

- Repeat the new statement daily for a month.
- Notice how it influences your feelings and behaviors over time.

Message to You

Self-confidence and self-awareness are not destinations but ongoing journeys. With every step toward understanding ourselves, accepting our truth, and making peace with our past, we find ourselves closer to the life we deserve.

Always remember: You are more than your successes or failures. You are more than others’ words about you. You are your identity, your essence, your truth.

What’s Next?

In the next chapter, we’ll discuss psychological and personal crises stemming from neglecting oneself and suppressing one’s true identity.

Chapter Eight

Psychological Disorders Resulting from Self-Neglect

Dear Reader,

Self-neglect is the silent enemy that infiltrates your life unnoticed, slowly weakening your mental strength and leaving its mark on every aspect of your existence. It's not just about skipping a break or neglecting physical health—it's ignoring your essence, the core of who you are, which craves love and care. This chapter is an invitation to understand how self-neglect profoundly impacts mental health and becomes a gateway to various psychological disorders. Supported by scientific evidence and undeniable truths, let's uncover this critical topic.

1. Generalized Anxiety Disorder (GAD)

Generalized anxiety disorder is a mental health condition characterized by excessive and persistent worry about various aspects of daily life, even if the concerns are minor or inherently non-threatening. Individuals experience racing thoughts, as though their minds are trapped in an endless loop of fears and negative expectations. This constant state of tension and hyper-vigilance occurs despite the absence of real threats. Symptoms extend beyond the psychological realm to include physical manifestations such as recurrent headaches, muscle tension, and sleep disturbances, making daily life a continuous struggle. Behaviorally, sufferers often avoid social situations or seek constant reassurance from others, reinforcing the cycle of anxiety and making it increasingly challenging to manage.

Treatment Approaches:

Effective psychological treatments for GAD include cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), which incorporates exposure techniques to gradually confront fears and reduce sensitivity to triggers. Supportive therapy also plays a vital role, providing a safe space for individuals to express their emotions and understand the roots of their anxiety. Relaxation-based therapies, such as meditation and deep breathing exercises, help calm the nervous system and mitigate responses to everyday stressors.

2. Major Depressive Disorder (MDD)

Major depressive disorder is a complex mental condition far beyond fleeting sadness. It manifests as a pervasive sense of emptiness and despair, robbing individuals of passion for

activities that once brought joy. Life appears colorless and bleak, and daily tasks feel like an overwhelming burden draining both mental and physical energy. Negative thoughts about the future and feelings of worthlessness entrap sufferers in a closed loop of pessimism and helplessness. Concentration becomes difficult, decisions feel impossible, and the mind is often trapped between the pain of the past and a future that seems devoid of hope. Professional performance and social interactions deteriorate, as individuals withdraw emotionally and experience a profound disconnection from themselves and the world around them.

Treatment Approaches:

Treatment includes CBT to reshape negative thoughts and foster a positive outlook. Psychodynamic therapy delves into deep emotional roots and addresses past traumas. Dialectical behavior therapy (DBT) complements CBT by teaching skills to manage intense emotions and engage with sensory experiences to improve daily life quality. Supportive therapy provides a safe space to express feelings and seek solace. In some cases, medical treatments like antidepressants are recommended under professional supervision to alleviate persistent symptoms and enhance therapy effectiveness.

3. Body Dysmorphic Disorder (BDD)

BDD is a mental health condition where individuals are excessively preoccupied with perceived physical flaws that may be imaginary or exaggerated. This results in significant psychological distress and disruption to daily life. Sufferers have persistent thoughts about their appearance, engaging in compulsive behaviors such as frequently checking mirrors or avoiding them entirely. They may attempt to hide perceived flaws with makeup or clothing, accompanied by ongoing feelings of shame and embarrassment. These issues stem from psychological factors like bullying or physical criticism, as well as biological aspects such as overactivity in brain areas responsible for analyzing details. Social pressures and unrealistic beauty standards exacerbate symptoms, leading to anxiety, depression, and social isolation.

Treatment Approaches:

Treatment typically involves CBT, focusing on challenging distorted thoughts about appearance and reducing compulsive behaviors like mirror-checking. Exposure and response prevention therapy teaches individuals to face anxiety-provoking situations without resorting to hiding or excessive checking. In severe cases, selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors (SSRIs) may be prescribed to reduce obsessive thoughts. Supportive therapy and coping skills training further help individuals build a healthy self-image and enhance life quality.

4. Borderline Personality Disorder (BPD)

BPD is a complex mental health condition marked by extreme emotional instability and difficulties in maintaining relationships and self-image. Individuals experience constant emotional swings, quickly shifting from intense love to anger or fear of abandonment. They live with perpetual anxiety about being left or rejected, even in stable relationships. Controlling emotions is challenging, leading to episodes of anger or deep sadness. A distorted self-image often results in feelings of inadequacy or unworthiness of love, creating a vicious cycle of extreme emotions and conflicting feelings. These emotions may manifest in impulsive or self-destructive behaviors, such as self-harm or engaging in risky actions to escape inner pain and emotional emptiness.

Treatment Approaches:

DBT is the first-line treatment, focusing on improving emotional regulation, enhancing stability, and developing better strategies for managing emotions and behaviors to foster healthy relationships. Psychodynamic therapy addresses deep emotional roots, especially childhood traumas, that contribute to the disorder. In some cases, medications like antidepressants or anti-anxiety drugs help manage accompanying symptoms like depression and anxiety. Group therapy provides social support and improves communication and interaction skills.

5. Eating Disorders (Anorexia Nervosa and Bulimia Nervosa)

Eating disorders are severe mental health conditions characterized by unhealthy eating patterns linked to distorted body image and self-esteem issues. These include anorexia nervosa, where individuals compulsively avoid food out of fear of weight gain despite being significantly underweight, and bulimia nervosa, marked by episodes of binge eating followed by compensatory behaviors like purging or extreme fasting. Sufferers often tie their self-worth to their weight or appearance, creating a cycle of over-controlling or losing control over food, accompanied by guilt and shame.

Treatment Approaches:

CBT remains the most effective therapy, targeting negative thoughts about the body and food while fostering healthy eating habits. Acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT) helps individuals accept negative emotions without resorting to harmful behaviors. Family-based therapy engages family members, especially for young individuals, to promote support and a healthy eating environment. Nutritional therapy under a dietitian's guidance restores balance and promotes healthy eating patterns.

6. *Burnout Disorder*

Burnout is a condition of emotional, physical, and mental exhaustion caused by prolonged exposure to stress, particularly in work or life-intensive tasks. Sufferers feel entirely drained, unable to complete even simple daily tasks. They lose motivation and energy, feeling as though everything is beyond their capacity to handle. This is accompanied by persistent frustration, low productivity, and a lack of accomplishment or purpose. Concentration difficulties and deteriorating social relationships further lead to isolation and depression if left untreated.

Treatment Approaches:

CBT helps restructure negative thought patterns, develop time management skills, and prioritize effectively. Therapy focuses on identifying stress triggers and adopting practical coping strategies, like setting boundaries and practicing relaxation techniques. Supportive therapy provides a safe space to explore emotions and understand deeper causes of burnout. In advanced cases, medications for anxiety or depression may be considered. Stress management training and relaxation techniques, like mindfulness and deep breathing, enhance psychological balance and resilience against daily pressures.

7. *Sleep Disorders (Insomnia)*

Insomnia is a mental health condition affecting the ability to fall or stay asleep, resulting in restless nights with persistent tossing and turning. Sleep becomes elusive, leaving individuals exhausted during the day due to insufficient or poor-quality rest. This condition often brings anxiety and worry about falling asleep, creating a vicious cycle of fatigue, mood disturbances, and reduced daily performance.

Treatment Approaches:

CBT for insomnia (CBT-I) is the most effective treatment, focusing on restructuring negative thoughts about sleep and fostering healthy sleep habits, such as maintaining a consistent bedtime routine and avoiding stimulants before sleep. Stimulus control therapy reinforces the association between the bed and sleep. Relaxation techniques and meditation alleviate stress and calm the mind before bedtime. Temporary medication, under medical supervision, may be necessary but is used sparingly to avoid dependence. Resetting the biological clock by maintaining fixed sleep and wake times enhances sleep quality and restores natural cycles.

Message to You:

Self-neglect is not just a passing behavior, it silently disrupts your inner balance. But the power to change lies in your hands. By using psychological therapies like CBT, you can reconnect with yourself and build a more balanced and peaceful life.

What's Next?

In the next chapter, we will explore why the past often dominates the present and influences future perceptions. Why does the mind insist on retaining painful and hurtful memories while overlooking moments of peace and tranquility? Stay tuned to uncover these mysteries and learn to break free from the grip of the past.

Chapter Nine

How Does the Past Define the Present, and Why Can't We Let Go?

Dear Reader,

Have you ever tried to move forward, only to feel the past pulling you back? Perhaps an old experience or painful memory resurfaces unexpectedly, dominating your thoughts and keeping you from living freely in the present. You may ask yourself, “Why am I stuck in memories that ended long ago? How can they feel stronger than my willpower?”

If you feel this way, you are not alone. This sensation is not a sign of weakness but rather a reflection of how the mind operates. Your mind wants to protect you, but in doing so, it keeps you tethered to the past, as if saying, “Don’t forget what happened; it might happen again.”

In this chapter, we will uncover how the mind processes the past, why it replays memories, and how you can break free from its grip. Each point will be examined in depth to understand why the mind acts this way and how to regain control.

1. Why Does the Mind Equate the Past with Reality?

Your mind is not just a tool for thinking and analyzing; it’s a guardian striving to always keep you safe. Its primary role is not to make you happy but to protect you from harm, even if that means recalling painful memories from the past. When faced with a new situation, your mind immediately compares it to past experiences, scanning for danger signals. If it finds similarities to a negative experience, it triggers a warning to keep you on guard. While this mechanism aims to protect you, it can become a barrier to progress.

How Memories Become Triggers

When you go through an emotionally charged event—whether joyful or painful, your brain stores the experience intensely. It doesn’t just record the details but also the emotions associated with them. These emotions act as markers or signals, bringing you back to that experience whenever you encounter a similar situation.

The brain prioritizes negative experiences because, from an evolutionary perspective, they serve as survival warnings. Negative experiences are often linked to fear or pain, prompting the brain to categorize them as “important” for future reference. For instance, if you experienced humiliation in a particular setting, your brain doesn’t just store the words spoken but also the feelings of shame and discomfort.

When you face a situation resembling painful experiences such as public speaking—your brain replays the memory associated with that type of event. It aims to warn you about potential danger based on the previous experience. This mechanism, called “defensive memory,” seeks to protect you from repeating the pain, even if the current situation is entirely different and poses no real threat.

2. Why Does the Past Feel Stronger Than the Present?

When you undergo a powerful emotional experience, your brain engages a structure called the **amygdala**, which is responsible for processing emotions, particularly those linked to fear and danger. The amygdala categorizes these emotionally charged memories as “significant.”

The amygdala remains on high alert, scanning for new situations that resemble stored emotional memories. When it detects similarities, it sends a warning signal, reminding you of the past event and the emotions you felt. This mechanism acts like an emotional guardian, continuously monitoring and storing memories associated with strong emotions as a defense mechanism. However, this natural process can become burdensome when it prevents you from engaging with the present freely and confidently.

The Role of Memory Amplification

When you experience something painful—like not achieving an important goal—your brain exaggerates the memory to make it seem more impactful than it actually was. The purpose of this amplification is to discourage you from repeating similar situations as a protective measure. However, this distortion warps your perception, making new opportunities seem riskier than they truly are.

For example, if you led a project in the past and faced significant obstacles, your brain amplifies that memory to make the failure seem catastrophic. Now, when considering a new project, you might feel fear and hesitation—not because you’re incapable of success but because your brain replays that exaggerated memory, stopping you from trying again. This automatic response, meant to protect you, can become a barrier that holds you back.

3. Where Does the Problem Lie?

Cognitive Distortions: When Thoughts Deceive Us

Cognitive distortions are errors the brain makes when interpreting situations in unbalanced or skewed ways. Instead of seeing the full picture, the mind focuses on the negative aspects of experiences, exaggerating them and turning them into “facts” that seem unchangeable. Negative thinking becomes the lens through which you view the world and yourself, leading to unrealistic perceptions that fuel anxiety and frustration.

For instance, if you failed in the past, your brain plants the idea: “I always fail.” Over time, this thought solidifies into a belief. Your brain reminds you of this “truth” in every new attempt, weakening your motivation and increasing hesitation. The brain stops recognizing other possibilities and becomes imprisoned by one negative experience, as if success were never an option.

Embedded Defensive Habits

When faced with challenges, the brain develops automatic responses to cope. You might remain silent when criticized or react with anger when frustrated. Over time, these responses become ingrained habits, activated even in situations where they are unnecessary.

Cognitive distortions and defensive habits reflect a mind trying to protect and survive, yet forgetting that life thrives not on fear but on flexibility and learning from experiences.

4. How Can the Body Help the Mind?

Three essential elements form the core pillars of supporting the mind and overcoming psychological challenges. These "Three Knights" stand by your side, empowering you to break free from psychological disorders and providing the energy needed for resilience and victory.

The Three Pillars:

1. Sleep

Sleep is not merely a means of physical rest but a vital time when the brain reorganizes and processes memories. During sleep, the mind reorders events and reduces their emotional impact, allowing you to face challenging situations with greater balance the next day. Sleep deprivation disrupts this process, leaving the brain more sensitive to painful memories and increasing stress and anxiety. Quality sleep acts as internal healing, offering clarity and emotional resilience.

2. Nutrition

What you eat nourishes not only your body but also your mind. Foods rich in omega-3 fatty acids, like salmon and walnuts, enhance brain health and cognitive performance. Reducing sugar and caffeine intake calms the nervous system, alleviating feelings of anxiety and tension. Providing your body with the right nutrients grants your brain the balance it needs to think clearly and make confident decisions.

3. Movement

Movement is a powerful tool for releasing mental stress and daily pressures. Physical activity stimulates the release of endorphins, known as happiness hormones, which improve mood and reduce the impact of negative memories. Even

a 15-minute daily walk can make a significant difference, restoring energy to the body and clarity to the mind.

5. How Can You Break Free from the Past?

Reframing Failure as a Lesson, not a Stigma

Instead of seeing failure as a permanent mark on your record, view it as a wise teacher offering priceless life lessons. Failure doesn't signify an ending but a new beginning full of possibilities. Shift your mindset from "I failed, so I'm a failure" to "I learned something new and am now better prepared to try again."

Self-Forgiveness

Forgiveness is the highest form of strength. Don't punish yourself for past decisions made with the knowledge and resources you had at the time. Forgiveness doesn't mean leniency but accepts that you are a continuously learning human being.

Focusing on the Present

Mindfulness is the gateway to liberation from the prison of the past. Immerse yourself in the "now" without judgment or comparison. Breathe deeply, close your eyes, and tell the past, "I am no longer your prisoner."

Message to You

The past is a part of you, but it doesn't have to define your future. You can reframe it and see it as a source of strength rather than a weakness. The present is your opportunity to write a new chapter in your life. Begin now because you deserve freedom and peace.

What's Next?

In the next chapter, we'll take tangible steps toward improving your physical and mental health through practical advice and structured plans. These will provide a flexible framework that you can follow or adapt to fit your unique needs and daily circumstances.

Get ready to discover how simple changes can create profound transformations in your life. Together, let's embark on this journey toward genuine care and balance.

Chapter Ten

Your Practical Plan for Achieving Mind-Body Balance

Dear Reader,

Did you know that every small decision you make daily about your food, movement, and even how you breathe can profoundly impact your mental and physical health? Research by Dr. Andrew Huberman, a neuroscientist at Stanford University, highlights how these daily habits are the key to balanced health and a calmer mind. In this chapter, we present a practical and comprehensive step-by-step plan to begin your journey toward a more balanced and peaceful life.

Nutrition Plan: Two-Week Meal Guide for Mental and Physical Health

Week One: Nourishing the Mind and Body

- **Breakfast:**
 - Oatmeal with almonds, walnuts, and banana.
 - Greek yogurt with honey and berries to support gut health and mood.
- **Lunch:**
 - A salad with leafy greens like spinach and arugula topped with grilled chicken breast.
 - Grilled salmon with broccoli, a rich source of omega-3 to boost brain function.
- **Dinner:**
 - Lentil soup with whole-grain bread for a light, energy-rich meal.
 - Brown rice with roasted vegetables and a side of quinoa.
- **Snacks:**
 - A handful of unsalted nuts to calm the nerves.
 - Vegetable sticks with hummus for a healthy energy boost.

Week Two: Energizing Every Cell

- **Breakfast:**

- Whole-grain toast with avocado and boiled eggs.
 - A green smoothie with spinach, banana, and almond milk to enhance focus.
- **Lunch:**
 - Tuna salad with olive oil and colorful vegetables.
 - Whole-grain wraps filled with hummus and fresh veggies.
- **Dinner:**
 - Whole-grain pasta with tomato and eggplant sauce.
 - A slice of grilled beef with sweet potatoes.
- **Snacks:**
 - Dark chocolate (70% cocoa or more) to stimulate happiness hormones.
 - A small handful of dates or raisins.

Foods That Trigger Stress and Panic Attacks

Caffeine Overload:

Excessive consumption of coffee or black tea overstimulates the nervous system, leading to insomnia and anxiety. Caffeine increases adrenaline and cortisol production, amplifying stress and reducing relaxation.

Refined Sugars:

Consuming refined sugars like sweets and pastries causes a rapid spike in blood sugar levels, followed by a sudden drop. This fluctuation leaves you feeling fatigued and stressed, affecting your nervous system and disrupting relaxation and sleep.

Processed Foods:

Highly processed foods like fast food and canned meats contain chemicals such as preservatives and artificial flavors, which disrupt hormonal balance and stimulate stress hormones like cortisol.

Salty Foods:

High-sodium foods elevate blood pressure, adding to physical strain and feelings of stress. Reducing salty foods promotes heart health and decreases anxiety.

Movement Plan: Rebalancing Hormones Through Simple Exercises

1. Simple Physical Exercises for Hormonal Balance

- **Brisk Walking:**
 - **Why?** Improves circulation and releases endorphins.
 - **How long?** 30 minutes a day, 5 days a week.
- **Resistance Training:**
 - **Why?** Builds muscle strength and balances stress hormones.
 - **Examples:** Push-ups and squats for 15 minutes, 3 times a week.
- **Stretching Exercises:**
 - **Why?** Relieves muscle tension and improves flexibility.
 - **Examples:** Stretch arms and legs for 10 minutes daily.

2. Breathing Exercises to Improve Focus and Reduce Stress

Research shows that balanced, deep breathing calms the nervous system and boosts dopamine release.

- **Deep Breathing Exercise:**
 1. Inhale slowly through your nose for 4 seconds.
 2. Hold your breath for 4 seconds.
 3. Exhale through your mouth for 6 seconds.
 4. Repeat for 5 minutes.
- **Double-Breath Technique:**
 1. Take two quick inhales without exhaling in between.
 2. Slowly exhale.
 3. Repeat 10 times.
- **Box Breathing Exercise:**
 1. Inhale for 4 seconds.
 2. Hold your breath for 4 seconds.
 3. Exhale for 4 seconds.

4. Pause for 4 seconds before repeating.
5. Repeat for 5 minutes.

Sleep Plan: Tips for Improving Sleep Quality

Did You Know?

Good sleep is the backbone of your mental health. Poor sleep disrupts emotional balance, while quality rest recharges the mind and body.

- **Stick to a Regular Schedule:**
 - Go to bed and wake up at the same time daily to regulate your body's internal clock.
- **Expose Yourself to Morning Sunlight:**
 - Natural light resets your biological clock, helping regulate sleep hormones.
- **Create a Comfortable Sleep Environment:**
 - Keep your room dark, quiet, and cool.
- **Avoid Evening Caffeine:**
 - Stop consuming caffeine at least 6 hours before bedtime.
- **Adopt Relaxation Rituals:**
 - Engage in activities like reading or meditation before bed to calm your mind.

Message to You

Your journey toward mind-body balance isn't a race but a series of small, sustainable steps. Choose what resonates with you from this plan and start now, because you deserve a life filled with calm, strength, and health.

What's Next?

In the next chapter, we will explore the transformative power of positivity and its ability to change your life. We'll discuss how to turn negative situations, discouraging thoughts, and even challenging obstacles into tools for growth and healing.

Positivity isn't just a fleeting feeling; it's a fundamental pillar of true transformation. When you start to see the positive aspects of your life, even amidst difficulties, change becomes not only possible but inevitable.

Prepare to discover tools and methods that will help you embrace positivity as a way of life and harness its power to build a new reality filled with clarity and strength. The transformation begins, let's continue this journey together!

Chapter Eleven

How to Surround Yourself with Positivity and Protect Yourself

Dear Reader,

Life is full of challenges, and its pressures can sometimes make us forget that we deserve to surround ourselves with peace and positivity. Your journey toward change and healing is not just an inner voyage but also a deep reflection on your surroundings, the people you interact with, the content you consume, and even how you perceive yourself.

In this chapter, we will explore how to create an environment that supports you and how to shield yourself from anything that weakens your spirit. This is not merely a lesson in improving your mental state but a practical guide to building a more balanced and radiant life, where positivity becomes an integral part of your day.

Recognizing Negative Relationships

1. How to Identify Negative Relationships

Your daily interactions can either serve as roots that nourish you with energy or as ropes that pull you down and weigh on your progress. Identifying negative relationships may seem straightforward, but it requires deep awareness of your feelings and a close observation of how others impact your life.

Signs of a Negative Relationship

- **Constant Criticism and Blame:**
When criticism becomes the primary focus of a relationship, it turns interactions into a constant source of stress and psychological strain. This undermines your self-esteem over time, leaving you feeling inadequate.
- **Bringing Up the Past:**
Some people insist on reopening old wounds you are trying to heal. Instead of offering support, they focus on your past mistakes, hindering your emotional progress and growth.
- **Draining Your Energy:**
Certain individuals leave you feeling emotionally and physically exhausted after every interaction. They take more than they give, leaving you burdened with negative emotions.

Practical Exercise:

1. Sit in a quiet place and make a list of people you spend most of your time with.
2. Next to each name, ask yourself:
 - "How do I feel after interacting with this person?"
 - "Do they inspire or drain me?"
3. Divide these individuals into three categories: supportive, neutral, and draining.
4. Create a plan to reduce interactions with those who negatively impact you.

2. How to Minimize Contact with Negative People

- **Set Boundaries:**
Communicate your limits clearly and assertively without hostility. For instance, you might say, "I'd prefer not to discuss this topic right now."
- **Limit Interaction Time:**
Spend less time with individuals who negatively affect you and redirect your energy to supportive people.
- **Seek Positive Connections:**
Fill the void of negative relationships with those who encourage and uplift you.

The Impact of Negative Media and Content

Does What You Consume Hurt You?

In the age of rapid information, news and sad content have become an inseparable part of our daily lives. But have you considered the profound impact this content has on your mental health?

How Negative News Affects You:

- Programs your brain to focus on threats, increasing anxiety and feelings of helplessness.
- Creates a pessimistic worldview that makes life feel overwhelming.

How Sad Movies and Music Affect You:

- Sad films deepen feelings of melancholy, keeping you stuck in a negative thought loop.
- Sad music can intensify painful emotions instead of helping you move on.

Practical Exercise:

1. Monitor the content you consume daily and ask yourself:
 - "Does this content make me feel calm or stressed?"
 - "Do I really need to follow this type of news or watch these scenes?"
2. Replace negative content with uplifting alternatives such as:
 - Reading motivational books.
 - Watching inspiring movies.
 - Listening to optimistic music.

Treat Yourself Like a Precious Gem

How to Rediscover Your Value

We are often our harshest critics, ignoring our needs and treating ourselves as if we matter less than others. The truth is, you deserve to treat yourself with love and respect, just as you would someone you deeply care about.

Practical Steps:

- **Be Your Own Best Friend:**
Offer yourself the understanding and compassion you would give to a friend during tough times.
- **Prioritize Time for Yourself:**
Dedicate daily moments to activities you enjoy, such as walking, journaling, or meditating.
- **Learn to Say “No”:**
Respect your personal limits and prioritize your needs without guilt.

Exercise to Practice Saying “No” Gently:

1. Identify common scenarios where you need to say no.
2. Prepare short responses, such as:
 - “I can’t right now, thank you for understanding.”
 - “I’m sorry, I can’t help with that.”
3. Practice saying these responses in front of a mirror, maintaining a calm tone.

Commit to Positive Change

Change Is Not an Event, but a Journey

True transformation takes time and consistent small steps. It's like planting a seed that requires patience and care to grow into a strong tree.

Practical Steps for Change:

- **Create a Personal Plan:**
Break your big goals into smaller, actionable steps. For instance, if improving fitness is your goal, start with short daily walks.
 - **Learn to Prioritize:**
Focus on activities and decisions that serve your personal growth.
 - **Celebrate Small Wins:**
Every small achievement matters and deserves recognition.
-

Message to You

Positivity is not a luxury, it's a daily choice to protect yourself from life's pressures. When you surround yourself with supportive relationships, consume uplifting content, and treat yourself with kindness, you create a life of balance and joy.

Yourself is your most valuable asset. Protect it, nurture it, and surround it with everything that brings you peace and positivity.

What's Next?

In the next chapter, we'll explore the seven essential elements that make therapy sessions successful and fulfilling. You'll discover how to maximize the benefits of therapeutic support and ensure you're on the right path to healing and growth.

Chapter Twelve:

Seven Realities to Expect When Undergoing Therapy

Dear Reader,

Right now, you might feel overwhelmed by a storm of dark thoughts and painful emotions, wondering, "*Can this darkness ever lift?*" Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT) isn't a magical wand, but it is a healing journey that begins with a bold decision to change your internal reality. Here are seven crucial insights you need to know before starting therapy:

1. Initial Evaluation and Goal Setting

When you step into your first therapy session, don't expect an instant miracle. Instead, prepare for a sincere encounter with yourself, guided by a compassionate and attentive therapist. During this session, you'll have the chance to unravel the tangled emotions and thoughts you've been carrying alone for years.

This is where pain transforms into words, confusion begins to clear, and the path to healing takes shape under the therapist's guidance. Therapy requires openness to change and a willingness to confront what lies ahead. Together, you and your therapist will set clear goals for reclaiming your sense of peace and confidence in facing life's challenges.

2. Building the Therapeutic Alliance

The relationship with your therapist isn't a formal, detached interaction but rather a deep, human connection. The therapist isn't a friend, neighbor, or anyone else familiar in your life; the therapeutic relationship is uniquely personal.

In sessions, you'll find someone who listens with genuine care, free of judgment or condescension. Over time, this interaction becomes a safe space where you can freely express yourself, turning feelings of isolation into shared understanding and support.

3. Gaining Self-Awareness

Self-awareness is the light that dispels the shadows of inner doubt. Therapy is not just a space for venting emotions, though that is a significant part of it. It's a place for studying your patterns of thought and behavior and understanding how they relate to your emotions.

Through therapy, you'll begin to notice recurring patterns in your life that you may have been unaware of. This newfound awareness becomes a powerful tool for reshaping your thoughts and emotions to align with reality rather than distorted perceptions.

4. Learning New Skills

CBT equips you with invaluable life tools that extend far beyond therapy sessions:

- **Cognitive Restructuring:** Learn to identify, analyze, and replace negative thoughts with balanced, fair ones.
- **Stress Management:** Discover effective techniques to calm yourself during tough times, from deep breathing to mental and physical relaxation strategies.
- **Problem-Solving:** Develop a practical approach to managing daily crises, enhancing your sense of competence and control over your life.

5. Daily Practice and Gradual Change

Change doesn't happen in a flash; it's a path that requires commitment and patience. The exercises you receive in therapy are tools, but you are the craftsman shaping your life.

You'll find yourself applying what you've learned in your everyday life, confronting anxiety with small steps, and celebrating progress, no matter how minor it seems. Over time, this gradual change becomes a way of life that supports your long-term well-being.

6. Facing Challenges and Setbacks

Even under the best circumstances, you may encounter difficult days when it feels like you're regressing. Don't view these moments as failures but as essential lessons for growth.

Setbacks aren't the end of the road; they're opportunities to recalibrate. You'll learn to forgive yourself and give yourself another chance every time you stumble. In therapy, setbacks are not failures; they're part of the process.

7. Understanding the Duration of Therapy

There's no one-size-fits-all timeframe for therapy. Your journey is individual and unique. Sessions may last a few weeks or extend for months, depending on the complexity of your issues and personal goals.

Remember, every small or slow step forward is genuine progress toward a more balanced and peaceful life. The duration of therapy largely depends on your openness, readiness, and commitment to the process.

Key Traits of a Good Therapist

A good therapist is not just a professional but a human who sees you in the depth of your pain and believes in your ability to heal. They must possess genuine empathy and deep flexibility to guide you with honesty and respect throughout your journey.

With the right therapist, you'll feel seen and understood, creating a space where you can grow and thrive.

The Ultimate Result: A Balanced and Resilient Life

If you give yourself an honest chance, you'll discover that you're stronger than you thought. Therapy teaches you to be your own friend, view your mistakes as opportunities to learn, and free yourself from the burdens of the past. You'll live a life filled with clarity, meaning, and tranquility—because you deserve to be happy and whole.

Thank You, and My Sincere Wishes for Your Healing Journey!

Sara Adham

